

Routine Correspondence

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COMMUNICATION AT WORK

In this scenario, a biotechnology company frequently corresponds through letters, memos, e-mail, instant messages, and text messages.

COMRMed, a wholesale provider of biotechnology equipment, is home-based in Reno, NV. COMRMed's CEO, Jim Goodwin, plans to capitalize on emerging nanotechnology to manufacture and sell the following:

- Extremely lightweight and portable heart monitors and ventilators
- Pacemakers and hearing aids, 1/10 the size of current products on the market
- Microscopic biorobotics which can be injected in the body to manage, monitor, and/or destroy blood clots, metastatic activities, arterial blockages, alveoli damage due to carcinogens or pollutants, and scar tissue creating muscular or skeletal immobility

COMRMed is a growing company with over 5,000 employees located in six cities and three states. To manage this business, supervisors and employees write on average over 5 letters, 10 memos, 50 e-mail messages, and numerous instant messages and text messages a day.

The letters are written to many different audiences and serve various purposes. COMRMed must write letters for employee files, to customers, job applicants, outside auditors,

Learning Objectives

When you complete this chapter, you will be able to

- Understand that memos, letters, e-mail, instant messages, and text messages are an important part of your interpersonal communication on the job and differ in destination, purpose, format, audience, tone, delivery time, and security
- Use an effective subject line including a topic and a focus
- Follow the all-purpose template for memos, letters, and e-mail including an introduction where you state what you want and why you are writing; a body or discussion section for stating the details; and a conclusion where you tell the reader what to do next and when
- Write different types of routine messages including inquiry, response, cover (transmittal), complaint, adjustment, and confirmation
- Consider the audience whether you are writing a memo, letter, e-mail, instant message, or text message
- Use wizards to format memos and letters
- Follow techniques in this chapter to create effective instant messages and text messages
- Use checklists to evaluate the success of memos, letters, and e-mail

governmental agencies involved in biotechnology regulation, insurance companies, and more. They write

- Letters of inquiry to retailers seeking product information (technical specifications, pricing, warranties, guarantees, credentials of staff, and so forth)
- Cover letters prefacing COMRMed's proposals
- Complaint letters written to manufacturers if and when faulty equipment and materials are received in shipping and adjustment letters to compensate retailers when problems occur

COMRMed's managers and employees also write memos to accomplish a variety of goals:

- Document work accomplished
- Call meetings and establish meeting agendas
- Request equipment from purchasing
- Preface internal proposals

To accomplish the majority of their routine correspondence, COMRMed's employees write many e-mail messages each day. These messages serve different purposes. Some e-mail messages are conversational. Other e-mail messages, however, must be professional in their style, organization, and content. This is especially true for e-mail messages sent to clients, vendors, and customers outside the company. These e-mail messages focus on timelines, deadlines, prices for service, meeting arrangements, cost breakdowns, procedural steps, and a host of other topics.

Finally, when COMRMed employees are working at distant locations, on the road, in hotels, or at the airport, they will use instant messages or text messages to ask each other quick questions or to casually check up on the status of a project.

Routinely, COMRMed employees spend a great deal of their time writing memos, letters, e-mail messages, instant messages, and text messages.

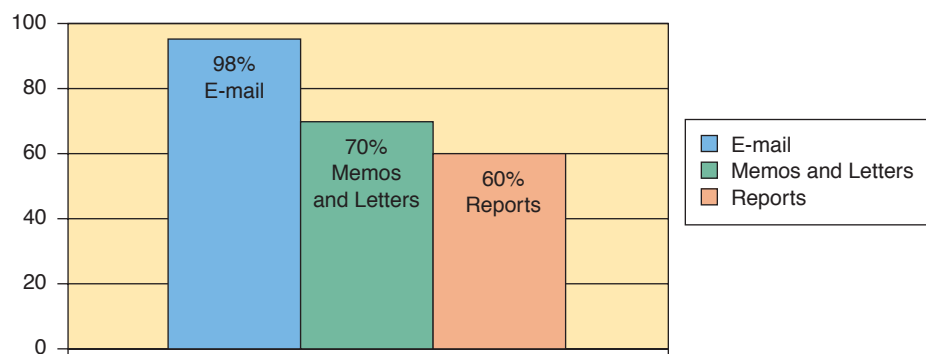
The Importance of Memos, Letters, E-Mail, Instant Messages, and Text Messages

On a day-to-day basis, employees routinely write memos, letters, e-mail messages, instant messages, reports, and text messages. The National Commission on Writing, in their *Writing: A Ticket to Work . . . Or a Ticket Out, A Survey of Business Leaders*, states that e-mail is “ubiquitous in the American economy” and that “more than half of all responding companies also report the following forms of communications as required ‘frequently’ or ‘almost always’: technical reports (59 percent), formal reports (62 percent), and memos and correspondence (70 percent)” (11). Figure 1 shows the significance of e-mail, memos, reports, and letters in the workplace.

This survey of “120 major American corporations employing nearly 8 million people” (National Commission on Writing) clearly states that you routinely can expect to write many e-mail messages, letters, memos, and reports on the job.

With the growing importance of mobile communication, instant messages and text messages also are written routinely on the job. According to Daniel Sieberg, reporter for CBS News, the number one use of smartphones is e-mail and texting. Talking on the phone actually ranks as the third function (Sieberg).

FIGURE 1 Percentage of Employees Who Consider E-mail, Memos, Letters, and Reports “Extremely Important”



Which Communication Channel Should You Use?

Memos, letters, and e-mail messages are three common types of communication channels. Other communication channels include reports, Web sites, blogs, PowerPoint presentations, oral communication, instant messages, text messages, and more. When should you write an e-mail message instead of a memo? When should you write a memo instead of a letter? Is an instant message or a text message appropriate to the situation? You will make these decisions based on your audience (internal or external), the complexity of your topic, the speed with which your message can be delivered, and security concerns.

For example, e-mail is a convenient communication channel. It is easy to write a short e-mail message, which can be sent almost instantaneously to your audience at the click of a button. However, e-mail might not be the best communication channel to use. If you are discussing a highly sensitive topic such as a pending merger, corporate takeover, or layoffs, an e-mail message would be less secure than a letter sent in a sealed envelope. You might need to communicate with employees working in a manufacturing warehouse. Not all of these employees will necessarily have an office or access to a computer. If you sent an e-mail

message, how would they access this correspondence? A memo posted in the break room or a text message sent to their handhelds would be better choices of communication channels.

The Differences Among Routine Correspondence Channels

To clarify the distinctions among memos, letters, e-mail, instant messages (IM), and text messages (TM), review Table 1.

TABLE 1 Memos vs. Letters vs. E-mail vs. Instant Messages and Text Messages

Characteristics	Memos	Letters	E-mail	IM/TM
Destination	Internal: correspondence written to colleagues within a company.	External: correspondence written outside the business.	Internal <i>and</i> external: correspondence written to friends and acquaintances, coworkers within a company, and clients and vendors.	Internal <i>and</i> external: correspondence written to friends and acquaintances, coworkers within a company, and clients and vendors.
Format	Identification lines include "Date," "To," "From," and "Subject." The message follows.	Includes letterhead address, date, reader's address, salutation, text, complimentary close, and signatures.	Identification lines: To and Subject. The Date and From are computer generated. Options include cc (complimentary copy), forwarding the e-mail message to others, and replying to numerous readers.	No format.
Audience	Generally high tech or low tech, mostly business colleagues.	Generally low-tech and lay readers, such as vendors, clients, stakeholders, and stockholders.	Multiple readers due to the internal and external nature of e-mail.	Multiple readers due to the internal and external nature of IM and TM.
Topic	Generally topics related to internal corporate information; abbreviations and acronyms often allowed.	Generally topics related to vendor, client, stakeholder, and stockholder interests; abbreviations and acronyms usually defined.	A wide range of diverse topics determined by the audience.	A wide range of diverse topics determined by the audience.
Complexity and Length of Communication	Memos usually are limited to a page of text. If you need to write longer correspondence and develop a topic in more detail, you might consider using a different communication channel, such as a short report.	Letters usually are limited to a page of text, though you might write a two- or three-page report using a letter format. If you need to develop a topic in greater detail than can be conveyed in one to three pages, you might want to use a different communication channel, such as a longer, formal report.	An effective e-mail message usually is limited to one viewable screen (requiring no scrolling) or two screens. E-mail, generally, is not the best communication channel to use for complex information or long correspondence. If your topic demands more depth than can be conveyed in a screen or two, you might want to write a report instead.	IM and TM are very brief communication channels with a limited number of characters—under 200.

(Continued)

TABLE 1 (Continued)

Characteristics	Memos	Letters	E-mail	IM/TM
Tone	Informal due to peer audience.	More formal due to audience of vendors, clients, stakeholders, and stockholders.	A wide range of tones due to diverse audiences. Usually informal when written to friends, informal to coworkers, more formal to management or external readers.	Very informal due to the limits placed on size.
Attachments or Enclosures	Hard-copy attachments can be stapled to the memo. Complimentary copies can be sent to other readers.	Additional information can be enclosed within the envelope. Complimentary copies can be sent to other readers.	Computer word processing files, HTML files and Web links, PDF files, RTF files, or downloadable graphics can be attached to e-mail. Complimentary copies can be sent to other readers.	Attachments can be sent using IM. You can send photo attachments with TM. However, sending file attachments with TM is limited.
Delivery Time	Determined by a company's in-house mail procedure.	Determined by the destination (within the city, state, or country). Letters could be delivered within three days but may take more than a week.	Often instantaneous, usually within seconds. Delays can be caused by system malfunctions or excessively large attachments.	Instantaneous.
Security	If a company's mail delivery system is reliable, the memo will be placed in the reader's mailbox. Then, what the reader sees on the hard copy page will be exactly what the writer wrote. Security depends on the ethics of coworkers and whether the memo was sent in an envelope.	The U.S. Postal Service is very reliable. Once the reader opens the envelope, he or she sees exactly what was written. Privacy laws protect the letter's content.	E-mail systems are not secure. E-mail can be tampered with, read by others, and sent to many people. E-mail stays within a company's computer backup system and is the property of the company. Therefore, e-mail is not private.	The same problems with e-mail security exist with TM and IM.

Reasons for Writing Memos, Letters, and E-Mail

You will write memos, letters, and e-mail to a wide range of readers. This includes your supervisors, coworkers, subordinates, vendors, stakeholders, customers, and multiple combinations of these audiences. Because of their frequency and widespread audiences, routine correspondence could represent a major component of your interpersonal communication skills within your work environment. Furthermore, memos, letters, and e-mail are flexible and can be written for many different purposes:

- **Documentation**—expenses, incidents, accidents, problems encountered, projected costs, study findings, hiring, and reallocations of staff or equipment.
- **Confirmation**—a meeting agenda, date, time, and location; decisions to purchase or sell; topics for discussion at upcoming teleconferences; conclusions arrived at; and fees, costs, or expenditures.
- **Procedures**—how to set up accounts, operate new machinery, use new software, or solve a problem.

FAQs: Why Write a Letter?

Q: Haven't letters been replaced by e-mail?

A: Though e-mail is quick, it might not be the best communication channel, for the following reasons:

1. E-mail might be too quick. In the workplace, you will write about topics that require a lot of thought. Because e-mail messages can be written and sent quickly, people too often write hurriedly and neglect to consider the impact of the message.
2. E-mail messages tend to be casual, conversational, and informal. Not all correspondence, however, lends itself to this level of informality. Formal correspondence related to contracts, for example, requires the more formal communication channel of a letter. The same applies to audience. You might want to write a casual e-mail to a coworker, but if you were writing to the president of a company, the mayor of a city, or a foreign dignitary, a letter would be a better, more formal choice of communication channel.
3. E-mail messages tend to be short. For content requiring more detail, a longer letter would be a better choice.
4. We get so many e-mail messages a day that they are easy to disregard—even easy to delete. Letters carry more significance. If you want to ensure that your correspondence is read and perceived as important, you might want to write a letter instead of an e-mail.
5. Letters allow for a "greater paper trail" than e-mail. Most employees' e-mail inboxes fill up quickly. To clean these inboxes up, people tend to delete messages that they don't consider important. In contrast, hard-copy letters are wonderful documentation.

- **Recommendations**—reasons to purchase new equipment, promote someone, award a contract to a vendor, or develop new software applications.
- **Feasibility**—studying the possibility of changes in the workplace (practices, procedures, locations, staffing, equipment, missions/visions).
- **Status**—daily, weekly, monthly, quarterly, biannual, yearly statements about where you, the department, or the company is regarding many topics (sales, staffing, travel, practices, procedures, or finances).
- **Directive (delegation of responsibilities)**—informing subordinates of their designated tasks.
- **Inquiry**—asking questions about upcoming processes or procedures.
- **Cover**—prefacing a proposal, long report, or other attachments.

Using an All-Purpose Template for Memos, Letters, and E-mail

Memos, letters, and e-mail contain the following key components:

- Introduction
- Discussion
- Conclusion

Figure 2 shows an ideal, all-purpose organizational template that works well for routine correspondence.

Introduction. Get to the point in the introductory sentence(s). Write one or two clear introductory sentences which tell your readers *what* topic you are writing about and *why* you are writing. The following example invites the reader to a meeting, thereby communicating *what* the writer's intentions are. It also tells the reader that the meeting is one of a series of meetings, thus communicating *why* the meeting is being called.

EXAMPLE ►

In the third of our series of sales quota meetings this quarter, I'd like to review our productivity.

FIGURE 2 All-Purpose Template

Introduction: Begin with a lead-in or overview stating *why* you are writing and *what* you are writing about.

Discussion: Include detailed development, made accessible through highlighting techniques, explaining *exactly what* you want to say.

*
*
*

Conclusion: State *what* is next, *when* this will occur, and *why* the date is important.

Discussion. The discussion section allows you to develop your content specifically. Readers might not read every line of your routine correspondence (tending instead to skip and skim). Thus, traditional blocks of data (paragraphing) are not necessarily effective. The longer the paragraph, the more likely your audience is to avoid reading. Make your text more reader-friendly by itemizing, using white space, boldfacing, creating headings, or inserting graphics.

BEFORE

This year began with an increase, as we sold 4.5 million units in January. In February we continued to improve with 4.6. March was not quite so good, as we sold 4.3. April was about the same with 4.2. May's sales increased to 5.6. June was our best month at 6 million units sold.

AFTER

Monthly Sales (in Millions of Units)

- January: 4.5
- February: 4.6
- March: 4.3
- April: 4.2
- May: 5.6
- June: 6.0

Conclusion. Conclude your correspondence with “thanks” and/or directive action. A pleasant conclusion could motivate your readers, as in the example below. A directive close tells your readers exactly what you want them to do next or what your plans are (and provides dated action).

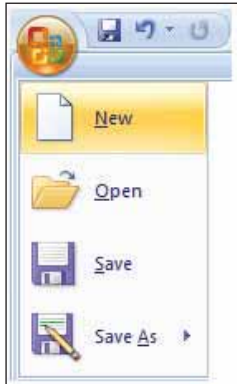
EXAMPLE ►

Congratulations! If our quarterly sales continue to improve at the current rate, we will double our sales expectations by 2014. Next Wednesday (12/22/14), please provide next quarter's sales projections and a summary of your sales team's accomplishments.

TECHNOLOGY TIPS

Using Memo and Letter Templates in Microsoft Word 2010

1. Click on the **Office** button located on the top left of your toolbar and scroll to **New**.



The following window will pop up.



2. Click on the type of document you want to write, such as Letters or Memos.

When you choose the communication channel, either of the following windows will pop up.



These templates and wizards are both good and bad. They remind you which components can be included in a memo or letter, make it easy for you to include these components, and let you choose ready-made formats. However, the templates also can create some problems. First, they are somewhat limiting in that they dictate what information you should include and where you should put this

(Continued)

TECHNOLOGY TIPS (Continued)

information. The content and placement of this information might contradict your teacher's or boss's requirements. Second, the templates are prescriptive, limiting your choice of font sizes and types. Our advice would be to use these templates and wizards with caution.

Essential Components of Memos

Memos, in addition to their introduction, body, and conclusion, must have identification lines. These include the date on which the memo is written, the name of the writer, the name or names of the readers, and a subject line, all followed by colons. See the example below:

EXAMPLE ►

Date: March 15, 2014
To: John Staples
From: Marilyn Andrews
Subject: Sales Projections for Fiscal Year 2015

The subject line is especially important because it summarizes the memo's content. One-word subject lines do not communicate effectively, as in the following flawed subject line. The "Before" sample has a *topic* (a what) but is missing a *focus* (a what about the what).

BEFORE

Subject: Sales

AFTER

Subject: Report on Quarterly Sales

The Memo Checklist will give you the opportunity for self-assessment and peer evaluation of your writing.

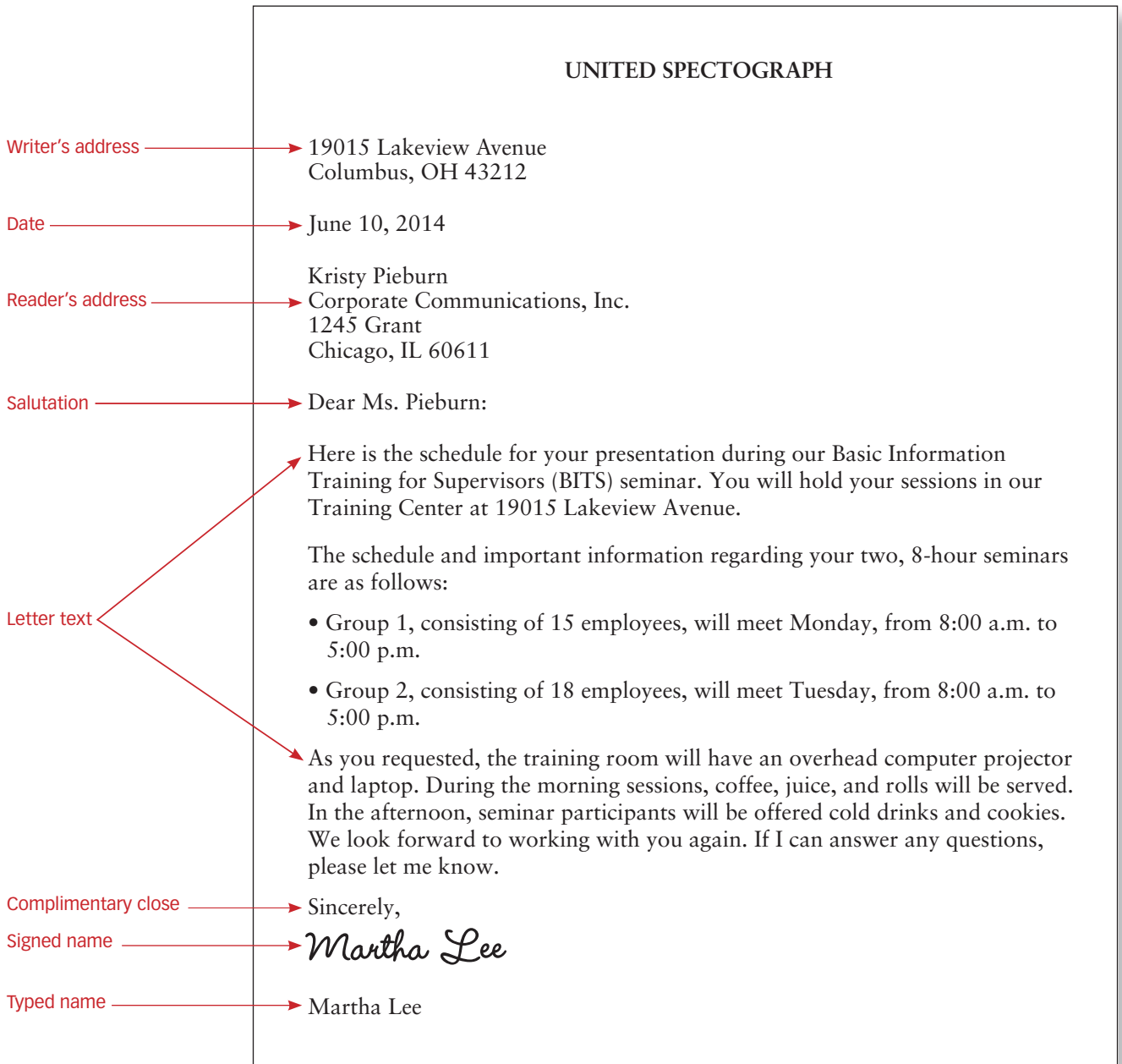
MEMO CHECKLIST

- | | |
|---|---|
| <p>_____ 1. Does the memo contain identification lines (Date, To, From, and Subject)?</p> <p>_____ 2. Does the subject line contain a topic and a focus?</p> <p>_____ 3. Does the introduction clearly state</p> <ul style="list-style-type: none"> • Why this memo has been written? • What topic the memo is discussing? <p>_____ 4. Does the body explain exactly what you want to say?</p> <p>_____ 5. Does the conclusion</p> <ul style="list-style-type: none"> • Tell when you plan a follow-up or when you want a response? • Explain why this dated action is important? <p>_____ 6. Are highlighting techniques used effectively for document design?</p> | <p>_____ 7. Is the memo concise, limiting the length of words, sentences, and paragraphs?</p> <p>_____ 8. Is the memo clear,</p> <ul style="list-style-type: none"> • achieving specificity of detail? • answering reporter's questions? <p>_____ 9. Does the memo recognize audience,</p> <ul style="list-style-type: none"> • defining acronyms or abbreviations where necessary for various levels of readers (high tech, low tech, and lay)? <p>_____ 10. Did you avoid grammatical errors? Errors will hurt your professionalism.</p> |
|---|---|

Essential Components of Letters

Your letter should be typed or printed on 8½" × 11" paper. Leave 1" to 1½" margins at the top and on both sides. Choose an appropriately business-like font (size and style), such as Times New Roman or Arial (12 point). Though “designer fonts,” such as Comic Sans and Shelley Volante, are interesting, they tend to be harder to read and less professional. Your letter should contain the essential components shown in Figure 3.

FIGURE 3 Essential Letter Components



Writer's Address. This section contains either your personal address or your company's address. If the heading consists of your address, you will include your street address and the city, state, and zip code. The state may be abbreviated with the appropriate two-letter abbreviation. If the heading consists of your company's address, you will include the company's name; street address; and city, state, and zip code.

Date. Document the month, day, and year when you write your letter. You can write your date in one of two ways: May 31, 2014, or 31 May 2014. Place the date one or two spaces below the writer's address.

Reader's Address. Place the reader's address two lines below the date.

- Reader's name (If you do not know the name of this person, begin the reader's address with a job title or the name of the department.)
- Reader's title (optional)
- Company name
- Street address
- City, state, and zip code

Salutation. The traditional salutation, placed two spaces beneath the inside address, is *Dear* and your reader's last name, followed by a colon (*Dear Mr. Smith:*). You can also address your reader by his or her first name if you are on a first-name basis with this person (*Dear John:*). If you are writing to a woman and are unfamiliar with her marital status, address the letter *Dear Ms. Jones*. However, if you know the woman's marital status, you can address the letter accordingly: *Dear Miss Jones* or *Dear Mrs. Jones*:

Letter Body. Begin the body of the letter two spaces below the salutation. The body includes your introductory paragraph, discussion paragraph(s), and concluding paragraph. The body should be single spaced with double spacing between paragraphs. Whether you indent the beginning of paragraphs or leave them flush with the left margin is determined by the letter format you employ.

Complimentary Close. Place the complimentary close, followed by a comma, two spaces below the concluding paragraph. The typical complimentary close is "Sincerely."

Signed Name. Sign your name legibly beneath the complimentary close.

Typed Name. Type your name four spaces below the complimentary close. You can type your title one space beneath your typed name. You also can include your title on the same line as your typed name, with a comma after your name.

Optional Components of Letters

In addition to the letter essentials, you can include the following optional components.

Subject Line. Place a subject line two spaces below the inside address and two spaces above the salutation.

EXAMPLE ►

Dr. Ron Schaefer
Linguistics Department
Southern Illinois University
Edwardsville, IL 66205

Subject: Linguistics Conference Registration Payment

Dear Dr. Schaefer:

You also could use a subject line instead of a salutation.

◀ EXAMPLE

Linguistics Department
Southern Illinois University
Edwardsville, IL 66205
Subject: Linguistics Conference Registration Payment

A subject line not only helps readers understand the letter's intent but also (if you are uncertain of your reader's name) helps you avoid such awkward salutations as "To Whom It May Concern," "Dear Sirs," and "Ladies and Gentlemen." In the simplified format, both the salutation and the complimentary close are omitted, and a subject line is included.

New-Page Notations. If your letter is longer than one page, cite your name, the page number, and the date on all pages after page 1. Place this notation either flush with the left margin at the top of subsequent pages or across the top of subsequent pages. (You must have at least two lines of text on the next page to justify another page.)

◀ EXAMPLE

Left, margin, subsequent page notation	Across top of subsequent pages
Mabel Tinjaca Page 2 May 31, 2014	Mabel Tinjaca Page 2 May 31, 2014

Writer's and Typist's Initials. If the letter was typed by someone other than the writer, include both the writer's and the typist's initials two spaces below the typed signature. The writer's initials are capitalized, the typist's initials are typed in lowercase, and the two sets of initials are separated by a colon. If the typist and the writer are the same person, this notation is not necessary.

◀ EXAMPLE

Sincerely,
W. T. Winnery
W. T. Winnery
WTW:mm

Enclosure Notation. If your letter prefaces enclosed information, such as an invoice or report, mention this enclosure in the letter and then type an enclosure notation two spaces below the typed signature (or two spaces below the writer and typist initials). The enclosure notation can be abbreviated "Enc.," written out as "Enclosure"; show the number of enclosures, such as "Enclosures (2)"; or specify what has been enclosed—"Enclosure: January Invoice."

Copy Notation. If you have sent a copy of your letter to other readers, show this in a copy notation. A complimentary copy is designated by a lowercase "cc." List the other readers' names following the copy notation. Type the copy notation two spaces below the typed signature or two spaces below either the writer's and typist's initials or the enclosure notation.

EXAMPLE ►

Sincerely,
Brian Altman
 Brian Altman
 Enclosure: August Status Report
 cc: Marcia Rittmaster and Larry Rochelle

The Letters Checklist will give you the opportunity for self-assessment and peer evaluation of your writing.

LETTERS CHECKLIST

- | | |
|--|---|
| _____ 1. Does your letter include the eight essential components (writer's address, date, reader's address, salutation, text, complimentary close, writer's signed name, and writer's typed name)? | _____ 6. Does your conclusion give directive action (tell what you want the reader to do next and when) and end positively? |
| _____ 2. Does the introduction state <i>what</i> you are writing about and <i>why</i> you are writing? | _____ 7. Is your letter clear, answering reporter's questions and providing specific details that inform, instruct, or persuade? |
| _____ 3. Does your discussion clearly state the details of your topic depending on the type of letter? | _____ 8. Have you limited the length of your words, sentences, and paragraphs? |
| _____ 4. Is your text accessible? To achieve reader-friendly ease of access, use headings, boldface, italics, bullets, numbers, underlining, or graphics (tables and figures). These add interest and help you readers navigate your letter. | _____ 9. Have you written appropriately to your audience? This includes avoiding biased language, considering the multicultural/cross-cultural nature of your readers, and your audience's role (supervisors, subordinates, coworkers, customers, or vendors). Have you created a positive tone to build rapport? |
| _____ 5. Have you helped your readers follow your train of thought by using appropriate modes of organization? These include chronology, importance, problem/solution, or comparison/contrast. | _____ 10. Is your text grammatically correct? Errors will hurt your professionalism. |

Essential Components of E-Mail

To convey your messages effectively and to ensure that your e-mail messages reflect professionalism, follow these tips for writing e-mail.

Identify Yourself. Identify yourself by name, affiliation, or title. You can accomplish this either in the "From" line of your e-mail or by creating a signature file or sig file. This sig file acts like an online business card. Once this identification is complete, readers will be able to open your e-mail without fear of corrupting their computer systems.

Provide an Effective Subject Line. Readers are unwilling to open unsolicited or unknown e-mail, due to fear of spam and viruses. In addition, corporate employees receive approximately 50 e-mail messages each day. They might not want to read every message sent to them. To ensure that your e-mail messages are read, avoid uninformative subject lines, such as "Hi," "What's New," or "Important Message." Instead, include an effective subject line, such as "Subject: Meeting Dates for Tech Prep Conference."

Keep Your E-mail Message Brief. Readers skim and scan. To help them access information quickly, "Apply the 'top of the screen' test. Assume that your readers will look at the first screen of your message only" (Munter, et al., 31). Limit your message to one screen (if possible).

SPOTLIGHT

How Is E-mail Used and Misused in Business Today?

Michael Smith, PE, President of George Butler Associates, Inc., an architectural-engineering consulting firm, supervises 270 employees, located in Kansas, Missouri, and Illinois. These include architects, engineers, scientists, and administrative support staff in human resources, marketing, information systems, and accounting.

Mike receives about 40 “meaningful e-mail” a day—and about 60 spam e-mail, attempting to tell him how to lose weight, buy gifts for his loved ones, make cost-effective travel arrangements, and so on. Mike deletes the spam, which is obvious at a glance in his e-mail in-box, and responds to the business-related correspondence.

He says that e-mail has been essential at GBA for at least two reasons:

The Good News:

1. **E-mail is fast and efficient.** For example, Mike finds that e-mail is ideal for setting up meetings with groups of individuals, including coworkers and clients. Before e-mail, he had to make multiple calls to his staff or customers, usually missing them while they were off-site. Or, he’d have to walk down the halls and up the stairs to leave messages on desks. Instead, with e-mail, Mike knows that the message will arrive at its intended location and that the recipients will respond.
2. **E-mail provides an “electronic record.”** When GBA used to rely more heavily on the telephone, people had trouble remembering to document conversations. With e-mail, you have a communication trail: multiple e-mail messages



reporting all communication that has occurred regarding a topic.

Unfortunately, Mike tells us that e-mail also has a few downsides.

The Bad News:

1. **E-mail lacks privacy.** Mike says that though phone calls made record keeping hard, they ensured privacy. All you needed to do was shut your office door or speak quietly. E-mail, in contrast, inadvertently can be sent to many people.
2. **E-mail can lead to inaccurate communication.** “Didn’t I read somewhere that 65 percent of communication is body language?” Mike asks. This leads to a second problem. With e-mail, the people involved can’t see each other’s eyes, hand motions, shrugs, smiles, or frowns, nor can they hear the grunts, groans, or laughs. Much of this body language is lost with electronic communication.
3. **E-mail can be depersonalized.** Body language not only helps communication, but also it personalizes. E-mail, Mike notes, can be impersonal. In some instances, especially those regarding “contentious situations,” Mike knows that a face-to-face discussion is the best way to solve a problem. In fact, Mike concludes that some people who are “conflict resistant” use e-mail as a way of avoiding person-to-person communication. To maintain good business relationships (with personnel as well as with customers), face-to-face talks often are needed.

Still, for speed and efficiency, e-mail is hard to beat.

FAQs: Professionalism in E-mail Messages

Q: Aren’t e-mail messages just casual communication? Isn’t it easy to write an e-mail message since you don’t have to worry about grammar or correct style?

A: Nothing could be further from the truth. E-mail might be your major means of communication in the workplace. Therefore, you must pay special attention to correctness.

Listen to what managers at an engineering company say about e-mail messages:

- “Most workplace communication is now via e-mail. Business e-mail needs to be almost as formal and as carefully written as a letter because it is a formal and legal document. Never send an e-mail that you would not be comfortable seeing on the front page of a newspaper, because some day you may.”
- “I see more and more new hires wanting to rely on e-mail. It is a totally ineffective way to resolve many issues on an engineering project. But they seem to feel it is okay for almost any communication. I suspect the general acceptance by their peers for this form of communication has led them to mistakenly assume the same is true for a business setting.”

(Continued)

(FAQ Continued)

- “Many people tend to be very ‘social’ in e-mails. Your employer owns your e-mails written on your work computers. They are NOT private. They can be used not only against you, but against your firm in court. For example, if I send an e-mail to a coworker that states in it somewhere what a lousy job Frank is doing on the such-and-such project and that project goes bad, it is possible that e-mail could end up in court and be used against my employer. In my mind all I was doing was venting my frustrations to an understanding friend and coworker. But, in reality, I am creating a permanent record of anything I say.”

(Gerson, et al. *Core Competencies*)

Organize Your E-mail Message. Successful writing usually contains an introductory paragraph, a discussion paragraph or paragraphs, and a conclusion. Although many e-mail messages are brief, only a few sentences, you can use the introductory sentences to tell the reader why you are writing and what you are writing about. In the discussion, clarify your points thoroughly. Use the concluding sentences to tell the reader what is next, possibly explaining when a follow-up is required and why that date is important.

Use Highlighting Techniques Sparingly. Many e-mail platforms will let you use highlighting techniques, such as boldface, italics, underlining, computer-generated bullets and numbers, centering, font color highlighting, and font color changes. Many other e-mail platforms will not display such visual enhancements. To avoid having parts of the message distorted, limit your highlighting to bullets, numbers, double spacing, and headings.

Be Careful When Sending Attachments. When you send attachments, tell your reader within the body of the e-mail message that you have attached a file. Specify the file name of your attachment and the software application that you have used (HTML, PowerPoint, PDF, RTF—rich text format—Word, or Works); and use compression (zipped) files to limit your attachment size.

Practice Netiquette. When you write your e-mail messages, observe the rules of “netiquette.”

- **Be courteous.** Do not let the instantaneous quality of e-mail negate your need to be calm, cool, deliberate, and professional.
- **Be professional.** Occasionally, e-mail writers compose excessively casual e-mail messages. They will lowercase a pronoun like “i,” use ellipses (. . .) or dashes instead of more traditional punctuation, use instant messaging shorthand language or “textese” such as “LOL” or “BRB,” and depend on emoticons (☺ ☹). These e-mail techniques might not be appropriate in all instances. Don’t forget that your e-mail messages represent your company’s professionalism. Write according to the audience and communication goal.
- **Avoid abusive, angry e-mail messages.** Because of its quick turnaround abilities, e-mail can lead to negative correspondence called flaming. Flaming is sending angry e-mail, often TYPED IN ALL CAPS. Readers can perceive the all caps as yelling, such as in the following example.

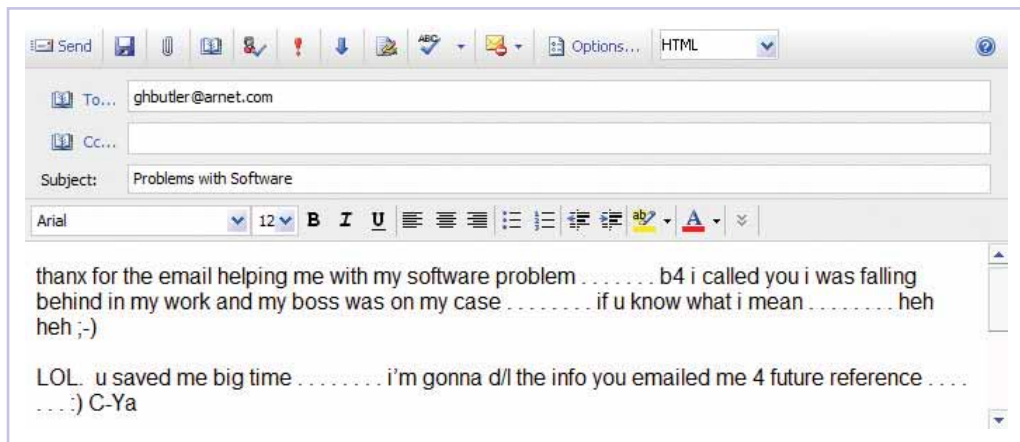
EXAMPLE ►

Subject: EXCESSIVE PRINTER PAPER

I HAVE TALKED WITH SEVERAL PEOPLE AND THIS SEEMS TO BE A PROBLEM IN YOUR DEPARTMENT. SOMEONE PRINTS INFORMATION AND WON’T PICK IT UP AT THE PRINTER. THEN THE NEXT PERSON HAS TO

SORT THROUGH THE PRINTED MATERIAL TO FIND WHAT HE OR SHE WANTS. SOME PRINTOUTS ARE NEVER USED; THEY JUST SIT THERE FOR DAYS, GETTING IN OTHER PEOPLE'S WAY. PEOPLE SHOULD JUST PICK UP THEIR PRINTING AND GET IT OUT OF EVERYONE ELSE'S WAY. THAT'S ONLY COMMON COURTESY. BUT THE PEOPLE IN YOUR DEPARTMENT AREN'T EVEN REMOTELY CONSIDERATE OF OTHERS. IF YOU MANAGEMENT PEOPLE WOULD JUST DO YOUR JOBS, NONE OF THIS WOULD HAPPEN.

The following is an example of an unprofessional e-mail message.



◀ EXAMPLE

This e-mail is flawed due to its use of instant messaging abbreviations, lowercase text, ellipses (. . .), slang, and emoticons. Though these techniques might be appropriate for personal communication, avoid overly casual e-mail messages for job-related communication.

Use the e-mail checklist to evaluate your correspondence.

E-MAIL CHECKLIST

- | | |
|---|---|
| <p>_____ 1. Does the e-mail use the correct address?</p> <p>_____ 2. Have you identified yourself? Provide a sig (signature) line.</p> <p>_____ 3. Did you provide an effective subject line? Include a topic and a focus.</p> <p>_____ 4. Have you effectively organized your e-mail? Consider including the following:</p> <ul style="list-style-type: none"> • Opening sentence(s) telling <i>why</i> you are writing and <i>what</i> you are writing about. • Discussion unit with itemized points telling <i>what exactly</i> the e-mail is discussing. • Concluding sentence(s) <i>summing up</i> your e-mail message or telling your audience what to do next. <p>_____ 5. Have you used highlighting techniques sparingly?</p> <ul style="list-style-type: none"> • Avoid boldface, italics, color, or underlining. • Use bullets, numbers, headings, and double spacing for access. | <p>_____ 6. Did you practice netiquette?</p> <ul style="list-style-type: none"> • Be polite, courteous, and professional. • Don't flame. • Don't overuse textese. <p>_____ 7. Is the e-mail concise, limiting the length of words, sentences, and paragraphs? Have you limited your e-mail to one or two screens?</p> <p>_____ 8. Did you identify and limit the size of attachments?</p> <ul style="list-style-type: none"> • Tell your reader(s) if you have attached files and what types of files are attached (PPT, PDF, RTF, Word, etc.). • Zip large files. <p>_____ 9. Does the e-mail recognize audience?</p> <ul style="list-style-type: none"> • Define acronyms or abbreviations where necessary. • Consider a diverse audience (factoring in multiculturalism or gender). <p>_____ 10. Did you avoid grammatical errors? Grammar errors will negate your professionalism.</p> |
|---|---|

Criteria for Different Types of Routine Correspondence

Choosing whether or not to write a memo, letter, or e-mail message will be determined by your audience. Since letters go outside your company, the audience is usually a low-tech or lay reader, demanding that you define your terms specifically. In a memo, your in-house audience is easy to address (usually high tech or low tech). You often can use more acronyms and abbreviations in memos than you can in letters. Because e-mail messages are sent to both internal and external audiences, you have to determine the amount and type of information based on your knowledge of the audience.

You will write many different types of correspondence on a daily basis to both internal and external audiences including memos, letters, and e-mail messages. Some of the different types of routine messages include the following:

- Inquiry
- Response
- Cover (Transmittal)
- Complaint
- Adjustment
- Confirmation

Inquiry

If you want information about degree requirements, equipment costs, performance records, turnaround time, employee credentials, or any other matter of interest to you or your company, you can request that information in a letter, memo, or e-mail. Inquiries demand specificity. For example, if you write, “Please send me any information you have on your computer systems,” you are in trouble. You will either receive any information the reader chooses to give you or none at all. Look at the following flawed example from a biochemical waste disposal company.

BEFORE

Please send us information about the following filter pools:

1. East Lime Pool
2. West Sulphate Pool
3. East Aggregate Pool

Thank you.

The reader replied as follows:

I would be happy to provide you with any information you would like. However, you need to tell me what information you require about the pools.

I look forward to your response.

The first writer, recognizing the error, rewrote as follows:

AFTER

My company, Jackson County Hazardous Waste Disposal, Inc., needs to purchase new waste receptacles. One of our clients used your products in the past and recommended you. Please send us information about the following:

1. Lime Pool—costs, warranties, time of installation, and dimensions
2. Sulphate Pool—costs, material, and levels of acidity
3. Aggregate Pool—costs, flammability, maintenance, and discoloration

We plan to install our pools by March 12. We would appreciate your response by February 20. Thank you.

Providing specific details saves your readers time by quantifying your request.

To compose your inquiry, include the following:

Introduction. Clarify your intent in the introduction. Until you tell your readers why you are writing, they do not know. It is your responsibility to clarify your intent and explain your rationale for writing. Also tell your reader immediately what you are writing about (the subject matter of your inquiry).

Discussion. Specify your needs in the discussion. To ensure that you get the response you want, ask precise questions or list specific topics of inquiry. You must quantify. For example, rather than vaguely asking about machinery specifications, you should ask more precisely about “specifications for the 12R403B Copier.” Rather than asking, “Will the roofing material cover a large surface?” you need to quantify—“Will the roofing material cover 150' × 180'?”

Conclusion. Conclude precisely. First, explain when you need a response. Do not write, “Please respond as soon as possible.” Tell the reader exactly when you need your answers. Second, to sell your readers on the importance of this date, explain why you need answers by the date given. Figure 4 is a sample inquiry letter.

FIGURE 4 Letter of Inquiry

COMRMed

8713 Hillview Reno, NV 32901 1-800-551-9000 Fax: 1-816-555-0000
 September 12, 2014

Sales Manager
 OfficeToGo
 7622 Raintree
 St. Louis, MO 66772

Subject: Request for Product Pricing and Shipping Schedules

My medical technology company has worked well with OfficeToGo for the past five years. However, in August I received a letter informing me that OTG had been purchased by a larger corporation. I need to determine if OTG remains competitive with other major office equipment suppliers in the Reno area.

Please provide the following information:

1. What discounts will be offered for bulk purchases?
2. Which freight company will OTG now be using?
3. Who will pay to insure the items ordered?
4. What is the turnaround time from order placement to delivery?
5. Will OTG be able to deliver to all my satellite sites?
6. Will OTG technicians set up the equipment delivered, including desks, file cabinets, bookshelves, and chairs?
7. Will OTG be able to personalize office stationery onsite, or will it have to be outsourced?

Please respond to these questions by September 30 so I can prepare my quarterly orders in a timely manner. I continue to expand my insurance agency and want assurances that you can fill my growing office supply needs. You can contact me at the phone number provided above or by e-mail (jgood@COMRMed.com).

Jim Goodwin

Jim Goodwin
 Owner and CEO

In the introduction, briefly explaining why you are writing establishes the context of the inquiry for the audience.

A detailed and itemized list informs the audience the exact questions you need answered. If you write precise questions, the audience will be able to provide the information you are requesting.

Pleasantly state when and why you need a response by a specific date to encourage your audience. In the conclusion, you can also include detailed contact information not provided in the letterhead.

Response

In a response, you provide information, details, or answers to an inquiry. For example, you or your company might need to answer questions about quotes on equipment costs, maintenance fees, delivery options, and technical specifications on makes and models from various vendors. You might need to write a response with information about room availability at your hotel, food arrangements, technology and presentation equipment rental fees, presentation room setups, entertainment options, and transportation from the airport. Maybe a client needs to change its insurance carrier. Your insurance company responds to the inquiry with quotes for insurance premium costs, levels of coverage, deductibles, and accessibility of claims adjusters.

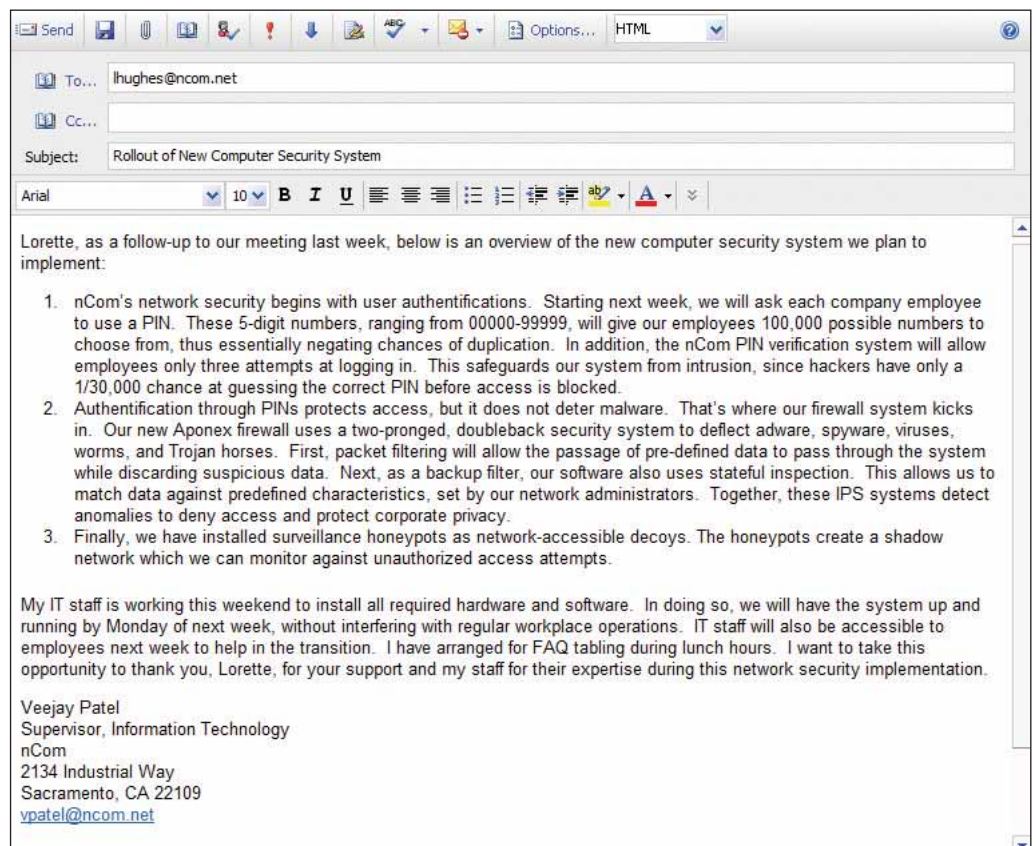
Introduction. Begin with a pleasant reminder of when you spoke with a person or heard from the audience. This explains *why* you are writing. Then, specifically state *what* topic you are writing about.

Discussion. Organize your discussion section into as many paragraphs as you need. When possible, remember to use bulleted or numbered lists for easier access. Include in this section the details or explanations needed. Consider including any of the following:

Times	Types of activities	Enrollment periods
Dates	Discounts	Enclosures
Amounts of people	Costs	Technology or equipment

Conclusion. End your response in an upbeat and friendly tone. You can also include your contact information (e-mail, phone number, address). See Figure 5 for a sample response e-mail.

FIGURE 5 E-mail Response



Anticipate questions the reader might have by including as much detail as possible. Using a list rather than sentences or paragraphs helps highlight key points.

Cover (Transmittal)

Cover or transmittal correspondence precedes attached or enclosed documents, informing the reader by giving an overview of the material that follows. In business, you are often required to send information to a client, vendor, or colleague. You might send the following kinds of attachments or enclosures prefaced by a cover letter, memo, or e-mail:

Reports	Invoices	Drawings
Maps	Contracts	Specifications
Instructions	Questionnaires	Proposals

Cover correspondence accomplishes two goals: tells readers up front what they are receiving and focuses your readers' attention on key points within the enclosures.

Introduction. What if the reader has asked you to send the documentation? Do you still need to explain why you are writing? The answer is yes. Although the reader requested the information, time has passed, other correspondence has been written, and your reader might have forgotten the initial request. Introductory sentences provide the reader information about why you are writing and what you are sending.

Discussion. In the body, accomplish two things. Either tell your reader exactly what you have enclosed or exactly what of value is within the enclosures. In both instances, you should provide an itemized list or easily accessible, short paragraphs. Page numbers are a friendly gesture toward your audience. You are helping the reader locate the important information. You are achieving audience recognition and involvement. However, including page numbers has a greater benefit than audience involvement. These page numbers also allow you to focus your reader's attention on what you want to emphasize.

Conclusion. Your conclusion should tell your readers what you want to happen next, when you want this to happen, and why the date is important. Figure 6 is an example of a successful cover memo.

FIGURE 6 Cover Memo Prefacing Attachments

Date: November 11, 2014
 To: COMRMed Management
 From: Bill Baker, Human Resources Director
 Subject: Information about Proposed Changes to Employee Benefits Package

As of January 1, 2015, COMRMed will change insurance carriers. This will affect all 5,000 employees' benefits packages. I have attached a proposal, including the following:

1. Reasons for changing from our current carrier	page 2
2. Criteria for our selection of a new insurance company	pages 3–4
3. Monthly cost for each employee	pages 5–6
4. Overall cost to COMRMed	page 7
5. Benefits derived from the new healthcare plan	page 8

Please review the proposal, survey your employees' responses to our suggestions, and provide your feedback. We need your input by December 1, 2014. This will give the human resources department time to consider your suggestions and work with insurance companies to meet employee needs.

Enclosure: Proposal

A cover memo directs the reader to the content in an attachment, such as a proposal. You can summarize the most important parts of the proposal, providing page numbers. In addition, your memo can include dated action so that the reader knows what to do next.

Complaint Messages

To write a complaint message, include the following:

Introduction. In the introduction, politely state the problem. To strengthen your assertions, include supporting details, such as the following: serial numbers, dates of purchase, invoice numbers, check numbers, names of salespeople involved in the purchase, and/or receipts. When possible, include copies documenting your claims.

Discussion. In the discussion paragraph(s), explain in detail the problems experienced. This could include dates, contact names, information about shipping, breakage information, an itemized listing of defects, or poor service.

Conclusion. End your letter positively. Remember, you want to ensure cooperation with the vendor or customer. You also want to be courteous, reflecting your company's professionalism. Your goal should be to achieve continued rapport with your reader. In this concluding paragraph, include your contact information and the times you can best be reached.

See Figure 7 for a sample complaint letter to an automotive supplies company.

Adjustment Messages

Responses to complaints, also called adjustment messages, can take three different forms.

- 100 percent Yes—you could agree 100 percent with the writer of the complaint.
- 100 percent No—you could disagree 100 percent with the writer of the complaint.
- Partial Adjustment—you could agree with some of the writer's complaints but disagree with other aspects of the complaint.

Table 2 shows you the differences among these three types of adjustment messages.

Writing a 100 percent yes response to a complaint is easy. You are telling your audience what they want to hear. The challenge, in contrast, is writing a 100 percent no response or a partial adjustment. Using a **buffer statement** delays bad news in written communication and gives you an opportunity to explain your position.

Buffers to Cushion the Blow. Use the following techniques to buffer the bad news:

- **Establish rapport with the audience through positive words to create a pleasant tone.** Instead of writing, "We received your complaint," be positive and say, "We always appreciate hearing from customers."

TABLE 2 Differences Among Adjustment Messages

	100 Percent Yes	100 Percent No	Partial Adjustment
Introduction	State the good news.	Begin with a buffer, a comment agreeable to both reader and writer.	State the good news.
Discussion	Explain what happened and what the reader should do and/or what the company plans to do next.	Explain what happened, state the bad news, and provide possible alternatives.	Explain what happened, state the bad news, and provide possible alternatives—what the reader and/or company should do next.
Conclusion	End upbeat and positive.	Resell (provide discounts, coupons, follow-up contact names and numbers, etc.) to maintain good will.	Resell (provide discounts, coupons, etc.) to maintain good will.

FIGURE 7 Complaint Letter

1234 18th Street
Galveston, TX 77001
May 10, 2014

Mr. Holbert Lang
Customer Service Manager
Gulfstream Auto
1101 21st Street
Galveston, TX 77001

Dear Mr. Lang:

On February 12, I purchased two shock absorbers in your automotive department. Enclosed are copies of the receipt and the warranty for that purchase. One of those shocks has since proved defective.

I attempted to exchange the defective shock at your store on May 2. The mechanic on duty, Vernon Blanton, informed me that the warranty was invalid because your service staff did not install the part. I believe that your company should honor the warranty agreement and replace the part for the following reasons:

1. The warranty states that the shock is covered for 48 months and 48,000 miles.
2. The warranty does not state that installation by someone other than the dealership will result in warranty invalidation.
3. The defective shock absorber is causing potentially expensive damage to the tire and suspension system.

I can be reached between 1 p.m. and 6 p.m. on weekdays at 763-9280 or at 763-9821 anytime on weekends. You also can email me at cdelatorre12@hotmail.com. I look forward to hearing from you. Thank you for helping me with this misunderstanding.

Sincerely,

Carlos De La Torre

Carlos De La Torre

Enclosures (2)

The introduction includes the date of purchase (to substantiate the claim) and the problems encountered.

The body explains what happened, states what the writer wants done, and justifies the request. This letter develops its claim with warranty information.

The letter concludes by providing contact information and an upbeat, pleasant tone.

- **Sway your reader to accept the bad news to come with persuasive facts.** “In the last quarter, our productivity has decreased by 16 percent, necessitating cost-cutting measures.”
- **Provide information that both you and your audience can agree upon.** “With the recession, many jobs in business and industry have been lost.”
- **Compliment your reader or show appreciation.** “Thank you for your June 9 letter commenting on fiscal year 2014.”
- **Make your buffer concise, one to two sentences.** “Thank you for writing. Customer comments give us an opportunity to improve service.”

- **Be sure your buffer leads logically to the explanation that follows.** Consider mentioning the topic, as in the following example about billing practices: “Several of our clients have noted changes in our corporate billing policies. Your letter was one that addressed this issue.”
- **Avoid placing blame or offending the reader.** Rather than stating, “Your bookkeeping error cost us \$9,890.00,” write, “Mistakes happen in business. We are refining our bookkeeping policies to ensure accuracy.”

See Figure 8, Figure 9, and Figure 10 for sample adjustment messages, which could be written as letters or e-mail.

Confirmation

In business, correspondence represents an official contract. Often, when clients and vendors make arrangements for the purchase of services or products, a confirmation letter, memo, or e-mail must be written to verify the details of the agreement.

FIGURE 8 100 Percent Yes Adjustment

Positive word usage (“Thank you”) achieves audience rapport.

The introduction immediately states the good news.

The discussion explains what created the problem and provides an instruction telling the customer what to do next.

The conclusion (“We appreciate your business”) resells to maintain customer satisfaction.

Thank you for your recent letter. Gulfstream will replace your defective shock absorber according to the warranty agreement.

The Trailhandler Performance XT shock absorber that you purchased was discontinued in April 2014. Mr. Blanton, the mechanic to whom you spoke, incorrectly assumed that Gulfstream was no longer honoring the warranty on that product. Because we no longer carry that product, we either will replace it with a comparable model or refund the purchase price. Ask for Mrs. Cottrell at the automotive desk on your next visit to our store. She is expecting you and will handle the exchange.

We appreciate your business, Mr. De La Torre. I’m glad you brought this problem to my attention. If I can help you in the future, please contact me at hlang@gulfstream.com.

FIGURE 9 100 Percent No Adjustment Beginning with a Buffer Statement

The introduction begins with a buffer. The writer establishes rapport with the audience through positive words to create a pleasant tone.

The discussion explains the company’s position, states the bad news, and offers an alternative.

Thank you for your May 10 letter. Gulfstream Auto always appreciates hearing from its customers.

The Trailhandler Performance XT shock absorber that you purchased was discontinued in April 2014. Mr. Blanton, the mechanic to whom you spoke, correctly stated that Gulfstream was no longer honoring the warranty on that product. Because we no longer carry that product, we cannot replace it with a comparable model or refund the purchase price. Although we cannot replace the shock absorber for free, we want to offer you a 10 percent discount off of a replacement.

We appreciate your business, Mr. De La Torre. I’m glad you brought this problem to my attention. If I can help you in the future, please contact me at hlang@gulfstream.com.

FIGURE 10 Partial Adjustment Stating the Good News in the Introduction

Thank you for your recent letter. Gulfstream will replace your defective shock absorber according to the warranty agreement.

The Trailhandler Performance XT shock absorber that you purchased was discontinued in April 2014. Mr. Blanton, the mechanic to whom you spoke, incorrectly assumed that Gulfstream was no longer honoring the warranty on that product. However, we no longer carry that product. We will replace the shock absorber with a comparable model, but you will have to pay for installation.

We appreciate your business, Mr. De La Torre. I'm glad you brought this problem to my attention. If I can help you in the future, please contact me at hlang@gulfstream.com.

Begin your letter with the good news.

Explain what happened, state the bad news, and provide a possible alternative.

For example, as head of corporate training, you met with a consulting firm to discuss services they could provide your company. After the meeting, you must summarize the results of the discussion, confirming payment, dates, and training content.

Introduction. In your introduction, remind the reader why the correspondence is being written and what topic is being discussed.

Discussion. The body clarifies the details of the agreement. Since this constitutes a legally binding document, you must specify anything agreed upon. Using highlighting techniques to make your content accessible, consider including any of the following:

Dates	Makes/models/serial numbers
Locations	Retainer fees
Times	Personnel and certification
Audiovisual equipment	Length of agreement
Costs	Menus and decorations
Parking	Room setup

Conclusion. The conclusion tells the reader what to do next. You might include a request for signature, payment due dates, or method of payment. See Figure 11 for a sample confirmation letter.

Instant Messages

Letters, memos, and e-mail could be too slow for today's fast-paced workplace. Instant messages are already providing businesses many benefits. A technical writer we know works for an international provider of business solutions and services. Her office is in Kansas City; her boss lives in Orlando and telecommutes. How do they collaborate while working on team projects from their dispersed work sites? They communicate by e-mail, telephone, teleconference, and an occasional face-to-face meeting when the boss travels to the writer's home office. However, for their required daily office "chats," they depend on instant messages.

Their IM of choice is IBM's Lotus Sametime Connect®. Sametime, their company's corporate standard for IM, allows the writer and her boss to see on their respective desktops two "floating screens," which can be moved around, minimized, or maximized as the reader chooses. The buddy list shows contacts by name and displays their status, whether

FIGURE 11 Confirmation Letter

Metro Consulting
 600 Broadway Albuquerque, NM 23006
 510-234-1818 www.metrocon.com

January 23, 2014

Mr. Carl Meyers
 ProfCom
 1999 Saguaro Dr.
 Santa Fe, NM 23012

Dear Mr. Meyers:

In response to your request, this letter confirms our discussion from last week. Below I summarize the agreement we reached regarding the training services your company will provide and the fees contracted.

ProfCom is scheduled to offer the following workshops in 2014:

- Fifteen days of “Customer Service” training to Albuquerque municipal employees. The workshops will be held throughout the city at locations to be determined later. Each location will provide technology, per your specifications. ProfCom will be paid \$500 for each half-day workshop and \$700 for each full-day workshop.
- Thirty days of “Managing Diversity” training to Albuquerque municipal employees. These workshops will be held in the Albuquerque Civic Center, 1800 Mountainview Dr. ProfCom will be paid \$900 a day for each of these workshops. Please contact Mr. Silvio Hernandez, 1-800-ALCIVIC, to request your technology needs.
- Ten days of “Supervisor/Management” training, leading to a “Supervisor/Management Certificate.” These workshops will be held in the Albuquerque City Hall, Conference Room A. ProfCom will be paid \$1,000 a day for each workshop. Please contact Mary O’Sullivan, 1-510-222-5150, to request your technology needs.
- Undecided additional training workshops, including “Ethical Decision-Making,” “Accounting for Non-Accountants,” and “Dynamic Presentation Skills.” We will work with you to schedule these as enrollment figures are calculated. MetroConsulting will pay ProfCom a monthly retainer fee of \$3,000 to ensure your availability for these workshops. The \$3,000 retainer will be adjusted against complete payment for services rendered.

Thank you for agreeing to provide us these services, Mr. Meyers. MetroConsulting is excited about the prospect of working with your firm. We hope to continue offering these workshops annually if both parties agree upon the success of the training. By signing and dating this letter of confirmation below, you indicate your agreement with the assigned services and compensation.

Rob Harken
 Rob Harken, Director

_____, Date: _____, Date: _____

The introduction explains why the letter is being written (“In response to your request”), specifies the type of letter (confirmation), and clarifies the topic (“training services” and “fees contracted”).

The letter’s discussion provides specific details regarding the agreement: costs, locations, and contact.

The conclusion ends positively and instructs the reader, stating what must be done next to confirm the agreement.

they are online, offline, available, unavailable, at a meeting, away for other purposes, and so on. The chat window displays the ongoing conversation (until it is closed, when it starts over).

Benefits of Instant Messages

Following are benefits of instant messages:

- Increased speed of communication.
- Improved efficiency for geographically dispersed workgroups.
- Collaboration by multiple users in different locations.
- Communication with colleagues and customers at a distance in real time.
- Avoidance of costly long distance telephone rates. Note: Voice over IP (VoIP) services, which allow companies to use the Internet for telephone calls, could be more cost-efficient than IM.
- More personal link than e-mail.
- Communication channel that is less intrusive than telephone calls.
- Communication channel that allows for multitasking. With IM, you can speak to a customer on the telephone or via an e-mail message and simultaneously receive product updates from a colleague via IM.
- Quick way to find out who is in the office, out of the office, available for conversation, or unavailable due to other activities.

(Hoffman; Shinder)

Challenges of Instant Messages

Instant messaging has potential problems in the workplace, including security, archiving, monitoring, and employee misuse (Hoffman; Shinder):

- **Security issues.** This is the biggest concern. IM users are vulnerable to hackers, electronic identity theft, and uncontrolled transfer of documents. With unsecured IM, a company could lose confidential documents, internal users could download copyrighted software, or external users could send virus-infected files.
- **Lost productivity.** Use of IM on the job can lead to job downtime. First, we tend to type more slowly than we talk. Next, the conversational nature of IM leads to “chattiness.” If employees are not careful, or monitored, a brief IM conversation can lead to hours of lost productivity.
- **Employee abuse.** IM can lead to personal messages rather than job-related communication with coworkers or customers.
- **Distraction.** With IM, a bored colleague easily can distract you with personal messages, online chats, and unimportant updates.
- **Netiquette.** As with e-mail, due to the casual nature of IM, people tend to relax their professionalism and forget about the rules of polite communication. IM can lead to rudeness or just pointless conversations.
- **Spim.** IM lends itself to “spim,” instant message spam—unwanted advertisements, pornography, pop-ups, and viruses.

Techniques for Successful Instant Messages

To solve potential problems, consider these five suggestions:

1. **Choose the correct communication channel.** Use IM for speed and convenience. If you need length and detail, other options—e-mail messages, memos, letters—are better choices. In addition, sensitive topics or bad news should never be

DOT.COM UPDATES

For more information about Instant Messaging, check out the following links:

- **Instant Messaging: The next wave in business communications** <http://www.expressitpeople.com/20040524/cover.shtml>
- **10 Tips for Using Instant Messages for Business** <http://www.microsoft.com/smallbusiness/resources/technology/communications/10-tips-for-using-instant-messaging-for-business.aspx>
- **IM for Business: Commercial Uses for the IM Community** http://im.about.com/od/imforbusiness/IM_for_Business_Commercial_Uses_for_the_IM_Community.htm

handled through IM. These deserve the personal attention provided by telephone calls or face-to-face meetings.

2. **Summarize decisions.** IM is great for collaboration. However, all team members might not be online when decisions are made. Once conclusions have been reached that affect the entire team, the designated team leader should e-mail everyone involved. In this e-mail, the team leader can summarize the key points, editorial decisions, timetables, and responsibilities.
3. **Tune in, or turn off.** The moment you log on, IM software tells everyone who is active online. Immediately, your IM buddies can start sending messages. IM pop-ups can be distracting. Sometimes, in order to get your work done, you might need to turn off your IM system. Your IM product might give you status options, such as “on the phone,” “away from my desk,” or “busy.” Turning on IM could infringe upon your privacy and time. Turning it off might be the answer.
4. **Limit personal use.** Your company owns the instant messages you write in the workplace. IM should be used for business purposes only.
5. **Never use IM for confidential communication.** Use another communication channel if your content requires security. As with e-mail, IM programs can let systems administrators log and review IM conversations (Hoffman; Shinder).

IM/TM Corporate Usage Policy

To clearly explain the role of IM and TM in the workplace, a company should establish a corporate IM and TM usage policy. Many industries already have such policies in place, in relation to existing restrictions established by Sarbanes-Oxley or HIPAA (Health Insurance Portability and Accountability Act). Consider a policy as follows:

- Train employees to use IM and TM effectively for business.
- Explain which services are allowable in the workplace. For example, conversation between coworkers is acceptable, but chat between employees and outside individuals might not be advisable. File transfers of proprietary information need to be restricted and monitored.
- Do not allow employees to store IM or TM passwords on computer desktops or other sites easily accessed.
- Install appropriate security measures, including automated encryption, to protect against external threats, such as spam, spim, and viruses.
- Log and archive instant messages and text messages for compliance to company policy (Ollman; “How To”; Bradley).

Text Messages

Text messages, also known as SMS (short message service), are a growing presence in workplace communication. According to the United Nations International Telecommunications Union, “the total number of text messages sent across the world is expected to reach 1.6 trillion . . . meaning that roughly 200,000 texts are sent every second” (Toor).

A unique characteristic of TM is its demand for conciseness. Text messages over 160 characters are delivered in multiple segments. Each segment is billed as a separate message. That’s why users try to limit messages to 160 characters—to save expenses.

“Pretty soon, you’re going to have to teach text messaging in your classes,” Robert Clark said. “Why’s that?” we asked. He responded, “Thirty percent of my interaction with staff is through text messaging” (Clark). Robert, a facilities manager for a real estate company, drives between eight apartment complexes to supervise his staff at each

location. Robert says that he depends on text messages instead of e-mail for the following reasons.

Reasons for Using TM

- **Cost.** Though Robert's cell phone is supplied by his employer, the staff that he supervises pays for their own cell phones. It's cheaper for them to use text messaging if their cell phone plans allow for unlimited TM.
- **Technological Access.** Staff members who work under Robert do not have computers at their work sites, nor does Robert have a computer in his car as he drives around town. However, all of Robert's employees have access to a cell phone.
- **Speed.** TM is a quick and easy way to communicate short messages, such as "John will be late for work today. Is it okay if I stay overtime?" That's 64 characters (counting the letters, spaces, and punctuation marks). Robert and his staff use other means of communication for longer correspondence.
- **Multitasking.** TM is a great way for Robert to multitask. Robert might be in a meeting, for example. He says, "If three of my staff need to attend training on a certain day, I can text all three employees right then and there and not disrupt the meeting. They'll respond quickly, allowing me to tell the meeting facilitator which of my employees can or can't attend. Then we can reschedule accordingly."
- **Decrease the "intimidation factor."** Many people don't like to write letters, memos, reports, or even e-mail messages. Many people don't like face-to-face communication, either. They're intimidated by writing or by bosses. Robert says that TM decreases this "intimidation factor" for his employees.
- **Documentation.** TM allows Robert to document his conversations, something that's not always possible with phone calls. TM is an instant record of a dialogue. A TM account saves incoming and outgoing calls for a few days until it's full. This allows an employee to clarify any later misconceptions.

The Writing Process at Work

The communication process is dynamic, with the three steps frequently overlapping. To clarify the importance of the communication process, look at how Jim Goodwin, the CEO of COMRMed, used prewriting, writing, and rewriting to write a memo to his employees.

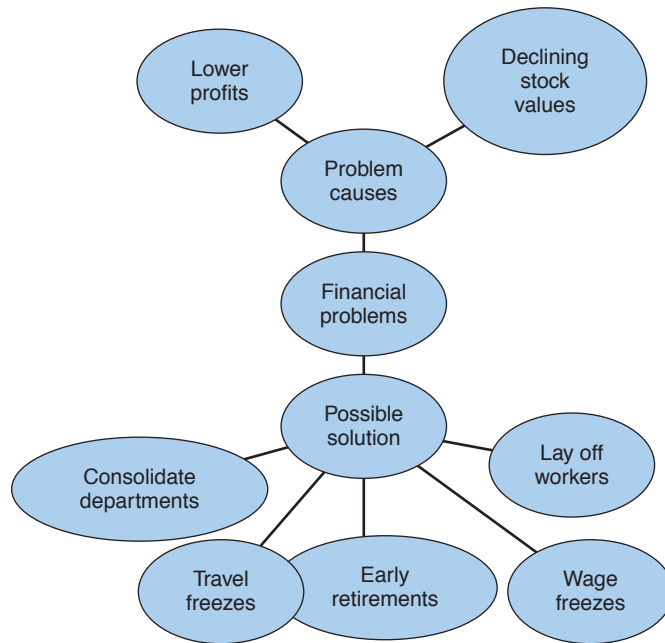
Prewriting

No single method of prewriting is more effective than another. Different types of prewriting techniques are geared uniquely for different types of communication. The goal of all prewriting is to help you overcome the blank page syndrome (writer's block). Prewriting will allow you to spend time before writing your document, gathering as much information as you can about your subject matter. In addition, prewriting lets you determine your objectives. Jim used mind mapping/clustering to gather data and determine objectives (Figure 12).

Writing

Once you have gathered your data and determined your objectives in prewriting, your next step is to draft your document. In doing so, you need to organize content.

Organize Your Ideas. If your supporting details are presented randomly, your audience will be confused. As a writer, develop your content logically. When you draft your

FIGURE 12 Mind Mapping/Clustering to Gather Data

Clustering helps you see the different parts of any subject. Clustering helps you develop ideas and see the relationship between these concepts. Because clustering is less restrictive and less structured than outlining, this prewriting technique might allow you to gather data creatively.

document, choose a method of organization that will help your readers understand your objectives. This could include comparison/contrast, problem/solution, chronology, cause/effect, and more. Jim drafted a memo, focusing on the information he discovered in prewriting and then received revision suggestions from his administrative assistant (Figure 13).

FIGURE 13 Rough Draft with Revision Suggestions

Add a focus to the subject line, such as "Problems with . . ."

I'd consider removing words like "as you know," "some," and "alot." Replace them with stronger words. Also, "alot" and "its" are spelled wrong.

List these problems and solutions to make them more accessible. Also, could you add more details?

Jim, I think you need to alter the tone of this memo. Is there some way to avoid talking about saving money by firing people?

Date: October 14, 2014
To: COMRMed Employees
From: Jim Goodwin
Subject: Problems

As you know, we are experiencing some problems at COMRMed. These include lower profits and stock value declines. We have alot of unhappy stockholders. Its up to me to help everyone figure out how to solve our problems.

I have some ideas I want to share with you. I'm happy to have you share your ideas with me too. Here are my ideas: we need to consider consolidating departments and laying off some employees. We also might need to freeze wages and certainly its time to freeze travel.

The best idea I have is for some of you to take early retirement. If all of you who have over twenty years vested in the company would retire, that would save us around 2.1 million dollars over the next fiscal year. And, you know, saving money is good for all of us in the long run.

Rewriting

Jim factored in his administrative assistant's suggestions and rewrote the memo. See Figure 14 for the finished product.

FIGURE 14 Problem-Solution Memo Incorporating Revision Suggestions

Date: October 14, 2014
 To: COMRMed Employees
 From: Jim Goodwin
 Subject: Suggestions for Improving Company Finances

COMRMed is experiencing lower profits and declining stock value. Consequently, stockholders are displeased with company performance. I have been meeting with the Board of Directors and division managers to determine the best course of action. Here are ideas to improve our company's financial situation.

1. Consolidating departments—By merging our marketing and advertising departments, for example, we can reduce redundancies. This could save COMRMed approximately \$275,000 over a six-month period.
2. Reducing staff—We need to reduce employees by 15 percent. This does not necessarily mean that layoffs are inevitable. One way, for instance, to reduce staff is through voluntary retirements. We will be encouraging employees with over 20 years vested in the company to take our generous early-retirement package.
3. Freezing wages—For the next fiscal quarter, no raise increases will go into effect. Internal auditors will review the possibility of reestablishing raises after the first quarter.
4. Freezing travel—Conference attendance will be stopped for six months.

I encourage you to visit with me and your division managers with questions or suggestions. COMRMed is a strong company and will bounce back with your help. Thank you for your patience and understanding.

CHAPTER HIGHLIGHTS

1. Memos, letters, e-mail, instant messages, and text messages are an important part of your interpersonal communication on the job.
2. Memos, letters, e-mail, instant messages, and text messages differ in destination, purpose, format, audience, tone, delivery time, and security.
3. Use an effective subject line including a topic and a focus.
4. Follow the all-purpose template for memos, letters, and e-mail including an introduction, a body or discussion section, and a conclusion.
5. The introduction states what you want and why you are writing.
6. In the discussion section, you state the details.
7. Conclude by telling the reader what you plan to do next or what you expect him or her to do next. You can also date this action and thank the readers for their time.

8. Consider the audience whether you are writing a memo, letter, e-mail, instant message, or text message.
9. Wizards allow you to format your memos and letters but can be somewhat restrictive.
10. Follow techniques from this chapter to create effective instant messages and text messages.

APPLY YOUR KNOWLEDGE



CASE STUDIES

After reading the following case studies, write the appropriate correspondence required for each assignment.

1. As director of human resources at COMRMed biotechnology company, Andrew McWard helps employees create and implement their individual development plans (IDPs). Employees attend 360-degree assessment workshops where they learn how to get feedback on their job performance from their supervisors, coworkers, and subordinates. They also provide self-evaluations.

Once the 360-degree assessments are complete, employees submit them to Andrew, who, with the help of his staff, develops IDPs. Andrew sends the IDPs to the employees, prefaced by a cover letter. In this cover letter, he tells them why he is writing and what he is writing about. In the

letter's body, he focuses their attention on the attachment's contents: supervisor's development profile; schedule of activities, which helps employees implement their plans; courses designed to increase their productivity; costs of each program; and guides to long-term professional development.

In the cover letter's conclusion, Andrew ends upbeat by emphasizing how the employees' IDPs help them resolve conflicts and make better decisions.

Assignment

Based on the information provided, write this cover letter for Andrew McWard. He is sending the letter to Sharon Baker, Account Executive, 1092 Turtle Hill Road, Evening Star, GA 20091.

2. ITCom is committed to increasing the diversity of its workforce and its clientele. ITCom realizes that a diverse population of employees and customers (in terms of gender, ages, races, and religions) makes good business sense.

To ensure that ITCom achieves diversity awareness, the company plans the following:

- Develop a diversity committee
- Focus on ways the company can be a responsible member of the community's diverse constituency
- Hire a diverse workforce
- Train employees to respect diversity
- Write corporate communication (Web sites, e-mail, letters, corporate reports) that accommodate the unique needs of a diverse audience

As CEO of ITCom, you want buy-in throughout the company. You want the company to realize that diversity is good for society and good for business.

Assignment

Write an e-mail message to your employees. In this e-mail, explain the company's diversity goals, highlight what the company plans to do to accomplish these goals, and ask the audience to participate in upcoming diversity workshops. Follow the criteria for effective e-mail provided in the textbook.

3. Mark Shabbot (mshabbot@Apex.com) works for Apex, Inc. at 1919 W. 23rd Street, Denver, CO 80204. Apex, a retailer of computer hardware, wants to purchase 125 new flat-screen monitors from a vendor, Omnico, located at 30467 Sheraton, Phoenix, AZ 85023. The monitors will be sold to Northwest Hills Educational Cooperative. However, before Apex purchases these monitors, Mark needs information regarding bulk rates, shipping schedules, maintenance agreements, equipment specifications, and technician certifications. Northwest Hills needs this equipment before the new term (August 15).

Assignment

Write an e-mail or letter of inquiry for Mr. Shabbot based on the preceding information.

4. Gregory Peña (gpena8@hotmail.com), 121 Mockingbird Lane, San Marcos, TX 77037, has written a complaint to Donya Kahlili (dkahl@TR.com), the manager of TechnoRad (4236 Silicon Dr., San Marcos, TX 77044). Mr. Peña purchased a computer from a TechnoRad outlet in San Marcos. The *San Marcos Tattler* advertised that the computer "came loaded with all the software you'll need to write effective letters and perform basic accounting functions." (Mr. Peña has a copy of this advertisement.) When Mr. Peña booted up his computer, he expected to access word processing software, multiple fonts, a graphics package, a grammar check, and a spreadsheet. All he got was a word processing package and a spreadsheet. Mr. Peña wants Ms. Kahlili to upgrade his software to include fonts, graphics, and a grammar check; a computer technician from TechnoRad to load the software on his computer; and TechnoRad to reimburse him \$400 (the full price of the software) for his trouble.

Ms. Kahlili agrees that the advertisement is misleading and will provide Mr. Peña software including the fonts, graphics, and grammar check (complete with instructions for loading the software).

Assignment

Write Ms. Kahlili's 100 percent yes adjustment to Mr. Peña based on the information provided.

5. You are the manager of WhiteOut, a store that sells snowboarding equipment and clothing. You have seven employees. Since you believed that today would be a light day for sales, you asked only one employee to work. However, suddenly, more customers than you had expected showed up, and you and your employee are overwhelmed. You need help—fast. E-mailing your other employees might not work, since they aren't necessarily near a computer. In contrast, you know they all have smartphones. The fastest and most trustworthy way to communicate with them is through instant messaging or text messaging.

Assignment

Write an instant message or a text message to the employees. Tell them the circumstances at your store and ask them for assistance.

INDIVIDUAL AND TEAM PROJECTS

1. Write an inquiry. You might want to write to a college or university requesting information about a degree program or to a manufacturer for information about a product or service. Whatever the subject matter, be specific in your request.
2. Write a cover message. Perhaps your cover letter, e-mail, or memo will preface a report you are working on in school, a report you are writing at work, or documentation you will need to send to a client.

3. Write an adjustment message. Envision that a client has complained about a problem he or she has encountered with your product or service. Write a 100 percent yes letter or e-mail in response to the complaint.

PROBLEM-SOLVING THINK PIECES

Northwest Regional Governmental Training Consortium (GTC) provides educational workshops for elected and appointed officials, as well as employees of city and state governmental offices.

One seminar participant, Mary Bloom, supervisor of the North Platte County Planning and Zoning Department, attended a GTC seminar entitled “Developing Leadership Skills” on February 12, 2014. Unfortunately, she was disappointed in the workshop and the facilitator. On February 16, Mary complained to GTC’s director, Sue Randall, stating her dissatisfaction. Ms. Bloom said that the training facilitator’s presentation skills were poor. According to Mary, Doug Aaron, the trainer, exhibited the following problems:

- Late arrival at the workshop
- Insufficient number of handouts for the participants
- Incorrect cables for his computer, so he could not use his planned PowerPoint presentation

Mary also noted that the seminar did not meet the majority of the seminar participants’ expectations. She and the other government employees had expected a hands-on workshop with breakout sessions. Instead, Doug lectured the entire time. In addition, his information seemed dated and ignored the cross-cultural challenges facing today’s supervisors.

Neither Sue nor her employees had ever attended this workshop. They offered the seminar based on the seemingly reliable recommendation of another state agency, the state data collection department. From Doug’s course objectives and resume, he appeared to be qualified and current in his field.

However, Mary deserves consideration. Not only are her complaints justified by others’ comments, but also she is a valued constituent. The GTC wants to ensure her continued involvement in their training program.

Assignments

1. Sue needs to write a 100 percent yes adjustment letter or e-mail. In this correspondence, Sue wants to recognize Mary’s concern, explain what might have gone wrong, and offer satisfaction. Write the 100 percent yes adjustment letter or e-mail.
2. Sue needs to write an internal memo or e-mail to her staff. In this memo or e-mail, she will provide standards for hiring future trainers. Write the e-mail to her staff, explaining why the e-mail has been written, what standards are needed, and when the responses are needed.

WEB WORKSHOP

Research information about text messages by reading the following online articles. Then, summarize your findings in an e-mail message to your professor.

- Calvey, Mark. "RU Ready? Wells Initiates Banking by Text Message." *Kansas City Business Journal*.
- Kedrosky, Paul. "Why We Don't Get the (Text) Message." *CNN.Money*.
- Noguchi, Yuki. "Life and Romance in 160 Characters or Less: Brevity Gains New Meaning as Popularity of Cell Phone Text Messaging Soars." *Washington Post*.
- Tedeschi, Bob. "Reaching More Customers with a Simple Text Message." *The New York Times*.
- "Text Messaging: Frequently Asked Questions." *AT&T*.

GRAMMAR, PUNCTUATION, MECHANICS, AND SPELLING

Correct organization and development of your memos, letters, or reports is important for the success of your technical communication. However, no one will be impressed with the quality of your work, or with you, if your writing is riddled with errors in sentence construction or punctuation. Your written correspondence is often your first contact with business associates. Many people mistakenly believe that only English teachers notice grammatical errors and wield red pens, but businesspeople as well take note of such errors and may see the writer as less competent.

We were working recently with a young executive who is employed by a branch of the federal government. This executive told us that whenever his supervisor found a spelling error in a subordinate's report, this report was paraded around the office. Everyone was shown the mistake and had a good laugh over it, and the report was then returned to the writer for correction. Our acquaintance assured us that all of this was in good-natured fun. However, he also said that employees quickly learned to edit and proofread their written communication to avoid such public displays of their errors.

Your writing at work may not be exposed to such scrutiny by coworkers. Instead, your writing may go directly to another firm, and those readers will see your mistakes. To avoid this problem, you must evaluate your writing for grammar, punctuation, and spelling errors. If you don't, your customers, bosses, and colleagues will.

Grammar Rules

To understand the fundamentals of grammar, you must first understand the basic components of a sentence.

A correctly constructed sentence consists of a subject and a predicate (some sentences also include a phrase or phrases).

EXAMPLE ►

The meeting	began	at 4:00 A.M.
subject	predicate	phrase

Subject: The *doer* of the action; the subject usually precedes the predicate.

Predicate: The *action* in the sentence

EXAMPLE ►

He	ran	to the office to avoid being late.
doer	action	phrases

If the subject and the predicate (a) express a complete thought and (b) can stand alone, you have an *independent clause*.

EXAMPLE ►

The meeting began	at 4:00 P.M.
independent clause	phrase

A *phrase* is a group of related words that does not contain a subject and a predicate and cannot stand alone or be punctuated as a sentence. The following are examples of phrases:

at the house
in the box
on the job
during the interview

If a clause is dependent, it cannot stand alone.

Although he tried to hurry, he was late for the meeting.
dependent clause independent clause

◀ EXAMPLE

He was late for the meeting although he tried to hurry.
independent clause dependent clause

◀ EXAMPLE

NOTE: When a dependent clause begins a sentence, use a comma before the independent clause. However, when an independent clause begins a sentence, do not place a comma before the dependent clause.

Agreement between Pronoun and Antecedent (Referent)

A pronoun has to agree in gender and number with its antecedent.

Susan went on *her* vacation yesterday.
The *people* who quit said that *they* deserved raises.

Problems often arise when a singular indefinite pronoun is the antecedent. The following antecedents require singular pronouns: *anybody*, *each*, *everybody*, *everyone*, *somebody*, and *someone*.

incorrect

Anyone can pick up *their* applications at the job placement center.

correct

Anyone can pick up *his* or *her* application at the job placement center.

Problems also arise when the antecedent is separated from the pronoun by numerous words.

incorrect

Even when the best *employee* is considered for a raise, *they* often do not receive it.

correct

Even when the best *employee* is considered for a raise, *he* or *she* often does not receive it.

Agreement between Subject and Verb

Writers sometimes create disagreement between subjects and verbs, especially if other words separate the subject from the verb. To ensure agreement, ignore the words that come between the subject and verb.

incorrect

Her *boss* undoubtedly *think* that all the employees want promotions.

correct

Her *boss* undoubtedly *thinks* that all the employees want promotions.

incorrect

The *employees* who sell the most equipment *is* going to Hawaii for a week.

correct

The *employees* who sell the most equipment *are* going to Hawaii for a week.

If a sentence contains two subjects (a compound subject) connected by *and*, use a plural verb.

incorrect

Joe and Tiffany *was* both selected employee of the year.

correct

Joe and Tiffany *were* both selected employees of the year.

incorrect

The bench workers and their supervisor *is* going to work closely to complete this project.

correct

The bench workers and their supervisor *are* going to work closely to complete this project.

Add a final *s* or *es* to create most plural subjects or singular verbs, as follows:

PLURAL SUBJECTS

bosses hire

employees demand

experiments work

attitudes change

SINGULAR VERBS

a boss hires

an employee demands

an experiment works

the attitude changes

If a sentence has two subjects connected by *either . . . or*, *neither . . . nor*, or *not only . . . but also*, the verb should agree with the closest subject. This also makes the sentence less awkward.

EXAMPLE ►

Either the salespeople or the warehouse worker *deserves* raises.
Not only the warehouse worker but also the salespeople *deserve* raises.
Neither the salespeople nor the warehouse worker *deserves* raises.

Singular verbs are used after most indefinite pronouns such as the following:

another	everything
anybody	neither
anyone	nobody
anything	no one
each	nothing
either	somebody
everybody	someone
everyone	something

Anyone who works here *is* guaranteed maternity leave.

Everybody wants the company to declare a profit this quarter.

Singular verbs often follow collective nouns such as the following:

class	organization
corporation	platoon
department	staff
group	team

The *staff* *is* sending the boss a bouquet of roses.

Comma Splice

A *comma splice* occurs when two independent clauses are joined by a comma rather than separated by a period or semicolon.

incorrect

Sue was an excellent employee, she got a promotion.

Several remedies will correct this error.

1. Separate the two independent clauses with a semicolon.

correct

Sue was an excellent employee; she got a promotion.

2. Separate the two independent clauses with a period.

correct

Sue was an excellent employee. She got a promotion.

3. Separate the two independent clauses with a comma and a *coordinating conjunction* (*and, but, or, for, so, yet*).

correct

Sue was an excellent employee, so she got a promotion.

4. Separate the two independent clauses with a semicolon (or a period), a conjunctive adverb, and a comma. *Conjunctive adverbs* include *also*, *additionally*, *consequently*, *furthermore*, *however*, *instead*, *moreover*, *nevertheless*, *therefore*, and *thus*.

correct

Sue was an excellent employee; *therefore*, she got a promotion.

or

Sue was an excellent employee. *Therefore*, she got a promotion.

5. Use a *subordinating conjunction* to make one of the independent clauses into a dependent clause. Subordinating conjunctions include *after*, *although*, *as*, *because*, *before*, *even though*, *if*, *once*, *since*, *so that*, *though*, *unless*, *until*, *when*, *where*, and *whether*.

correct

Because Sue was an excellent employee, she got a promotion.

Faulty or Vague Pronoun Reference

A pronoun must refer to a specific noun (its antecedent). Problems arise when (a) there is an excessive number of pronouns (causing vague pronoun reference) and (b) there is no specific noun as an antecedent. Notice that there seems to be an excessive number of pronouns in the following passage, and the antecedents are unclear.

EXAMPLE ►

Although Bob had been hired over two years ago, *he* found that *his* boss did not approve *his* raise. In fact, *he* was also passed over for *his* promotion. The boss appears to have concluded that *he* had not exhibited zeal in *his* endeavors for their business. Instead of being a highly valued employee, *he* was not viewed with pleasure by those in authority. Perhaps it would be best if *he* considered *his* options and moved to some other company where *he* might be considered in a new light.

The excessive and vague use of *he* and *his* causes problems for readers. Do these words refer to Bob or to his boss? You are never completely sure. To avoid this problem, limit pronoun usage, as in the following revision.

EXAMPLE ►

Although Bob had been hired over two years ago, he found that his boss, Joe, did not approve his raise. In fact, Bob was also passed over for promotion. Joe appears to have concluded that Bob had not exhibited zeal in his endeavors for their business. Instead of being a highly valued employee, Bob was not viewed with pleasure by those in authority. Perhaps it would be best if Bob considered his options and moved to some other company where he might be considered in a new light.

To make the preceding paragraph more precise, we have replaced vague pronouns (*he* and *his*) with exact names (*Bob* and *Joe*).

Fragments

A *fragment* occurs when a group of words is incorrectly used as an independent clause. Often the group of words begins with a capital letter and has end punctuation but is missing either a subject or a predicate.

incorrect

Working with computers.
(lacks a predicate and does not express a complete thought)

The group of words may have a subject and a predicate but be a dependent clause.

incorrect

Although he enjoyed working with computers.
(has a subject, *he*, and a predicate, *enjoyed*, but is a dependent clause because it is introduced by the subordinate conjunction *although*)

It is easy to remedy a fragment by doing one of the following:

- Add a subject.
- Add a predicate.
- Add both a subject and a predicate.
- Add an independent clause to a dependent clause.

correct

Joe found that working with computers used his training.
(subject, *Joe*, and predicate, *found*, have been added)

correct

Although he enjoyed working with computers, he could not find a job in a computer-related field.
(independent clause, *he could not find a job*, added to the dependent clause, *Although he enjoyed working with computers*)

Fused Sentence

A *fused sentence* occurs when two independent clauses are connected with no punctuation.

incorrect

The company performed well last quarter its stock rose several points.

There are several ways to correct this error.

1. Write two sentences separated by a period.

correct

The company performed well last quarter. Its stock rose several points.

2. Use a comma and a coordinating conjunction to separate the two independent clauses.

correct

The company performed well last quarter, so its stock rose several points.

3. Use a subordinating conjunction to create a dependent clause.

correct

Because the company performed well last quarter, its stock rose several points.

4. Use a semicolon to separate the two independent clauses.

correct

The company performed well last quarter; its stock rose several points.

5. Separate the two independent clauses with a semicolon, a conjunctive adverb or a transitional word or phrase, and a comma.

correct

The company performed well last quarter; *therefore*, its stock rose several points.

correct

The company performed well last quarter; *for example*, its stock rose several points.

The following are transitional words and phrases, listed according to their use.

TO ADD

again	in addition
also	moreover
besides	next
first	second
furthermore	still

TO COMPARE/CONTRAST

also	nevertheless
but	on the contrary
conversely	still
in contrast	

TO PROVIDE EXAMPLES

for example	of course
for instance	put another way
in fact	to illustrate

TO SHOW PLACE

above	here
adjacent to	nearby
below	on the other side
elsewhere	there
further on	

To Reveal Time

afterward	second
first	shortly
meanwhile	subsequently
presently	thereafter

To Summarize

all in all	last
finally	on the whole
in conclusion	therefore
in summary	thus

Modification

A *modifier* is a word, phrase, or clause that explains or adds details about other words, phrases, or clauses.

Misplaced Modifiers. A *misplaced modifier* is one that is not placed next to the word it modifies.

incorrect

He had a heart attack *almost* every time he was reviewed by his supervisor.

correct

He almost had a heart attack every time he was reviewed by his supervisor.

incorrect

The worker had to *frequently* miss work.

correct

The worker frequently had to miss work.

Dangling Modifiers. A *dangling modifier* is a modifier that is not placed next to the word or phrase it modifies. To avoid confusing your readers, place modifiers next to the word(s) they refer to. Don't expect your readers to guess at your meaning.

incorrect

While working, tiredness overcame them.
(Who was working? Who was overcome by tiredness? *While working* should modify *staff*, but the word *staff* does not appear in the sentence.)

correct

While working, the staff became tired.

incorrect

After soldering for two hours, the equipment was ready for shipping. (Who had been soldering for two hours? Not the equipment!)

correct

After soldering for two hours, the technicians prepared the equipment for shipping.

Parallelism

All items in a list should be parallel in grammatical form. Avoid mixing phrases and sentences (independent clauses).

incorrect

We will discuss the following at the department meeting:

1. Entering mileage in logs (phrase)
2. All employees have to enroll in a training seminar. (sentence)
3. Purpose of quarterly reviews (phrase)
4. Some data processors will travel to job sites. (sentence)

correct

We will discuss the following at the department meeting:

- | | | |
|--|---|---------|
| <ol style="list-style-type: none"> 1. Entering mileage in logs 2. Enrolling in training seminars 3. Reviewing employee performance quarterly 4. Traveling to job sites | } | phrases |
|--|---|---------|

correct

At the department meeting, you will learn how to do the following:

- | | | |
|--|---|-----------|
| <ol style="list-style-type: none"> 1. Enter mileage in logs. 2. Enroll in training seminars. 3. Review employee performance quarterly. 4. Travel to job sites. | } | sentences |
|--|---|-----------|

Punctuation

Apostrophe (')

Place an *apostrophe* before the final *s* in a singular word to indicate possession.

EXAMPLE ►

Jim's tool chest is next to the furnace.

Place the apostrophe after the final *s* if the word is plural.

EXAMPLE ►

The employees' reception will be held next week.

Don't use an apostrophe to make singular abbreviations plural.

incorrect

The EXT's will be shipped today.

correct

The EXTs will be shipped today.

Colon (:)

Use a *colon* after a salutation.

Dear Mr. Harken:

◀ EXAMPLE

In addition, use a colon after an emphatic or cautionary word if explanations follow.

Note: Hand-tighten the nuts.

Caution: Wash thoroughly if any mixture touches your skin.

◀ EXAMPLE

Finally, use a colon after an independent clause to precede a quotation, list, or example.

She said the following: “No comment.”

These supplies for the experiment are on order: a plastic hose, two batteries, and several chemicals.

The problem has two possible solutions: Hire four more workers, or give everyone a raise.

◀ EXAMPLE

NOTE: In the preceding examples, the colon follows an independent clause.

A common mistake is to place a colon after an incomplete sentence. Except for salutations and cautionary notes, whatever precedes a colon *must* be an independent clause.

incorrect

The two keys to success are: earning money and spending wisely.

correct

The two keys to success are earning money and spending wisely.

or

The two keys to success are as follows: earning money and spending wisely.

or

The two keys to success are as follows:

1. Earning money
2. Spending wisely

Comma (,)

Writers often get in trouble with *commas* when they employ one of two common words of wisdom.

- When in doubt, leave it out.
- Use a comma when there is a pause.

Both rules are inexact. Writers use the first rule to justify the complete avoidance of commas; they use the second rule to sprinkle commas randomly throughout their writing. On the contrary, commas have several specific conventions that determine usage.

ROUTINE CORRESPONDENCE

1. Place a comma before a coordinating conjunction (*and, but, or, for, so, yet*) linking two independent clauses.

EXAMPLE ►

You are the best person for the job, *so* I will hire you.
We spent several hours discussing solutions to the problem, *but* we failed to decide on a course of action.

2. Use commas to set off introductory comments.

EXAMPLE ►

First, she soldered the components.
In business, people often have to work long hours.
To work well, you need to get along with your coworkers.
If you want to test equipment, do so by 5:25 P.M.

3. Use commas to set off sentence interrupters.

EXAMPLE ►

The company, started by my father, did not survive the last recession.
Mrs. Patel, the proprietor of the store, purchased a wide array of merchandise.

4. Set off parenthetical expressions with commas.

EXAMPLE ►

A worker, it seems, should be willing to try new techniques.
The highway, by the way, needs repairs.

5. Use commas after each item in a series of three or more.

EXAMPLE ►

Prakash, Mirren, and Justin were chosen as employees of the year.
We found the following problems: corrosion, excessive machinery breakdowns, and power failures.

6. Use commas for long numbers.

EXAMPLE ►

She earns \$100,000 before taxes.

NOTE: Very large numbers are often written as words.

EXAMPLE ►

Our business netted over \$2 million in 2014.

7. Use commas to separate the day and year when they are part of a sentence.

EXAMPLE ►

The company hired her on September 7, 2014, to be its bookkeeper.

NOTE: If the year is used as an adjective, do not follow it with a comma.

EXAMPLE ►

The 2014 corporate report came out today.

8. Use commas to separate the city from the state and the state from the rest of the sentence.

The new warehouse in Austin, Texas, will promote increased revenues.

◀ EXAMPLE

NOTE: If you omit either the city or the state, you do not need commas.

The new warehouse in Austin will promote increased revenues.

◀ EXAMPLE

Dash (—)

A *dash*, typed as two consecutive hyphens with no spaces before or after, is a versatile punctuation mark. Most word processing programs now include an em dash character. Use dashes in the following ways.

1. After a heading and before an explanation.

Forecasting—Joe and Joan will be in charge of researching fourth-quarter production quotas.

◀ EXAMPLE

2. To indicate an emphatic pause.

You will be fired—unless you obey company rules.

◀ EXAMPLE

3. To highlight a new idea.

Here's what we can do to improve production quality—provide on-the-job training, salary incentives, and quality controls.

◀ EXAMPLE

4. Before and after an explanatory or appositive series.

Three people—Sue, Luci, and Tom—are essential to the smooth functioning of our office.

◀ EXAMPLE

Ellipses (...)

Ellipses (three spaced periods) indicate omission of words within quoted materials.

“Six years ago, prior to incorporating, the company had to pay extremely high federal taxes.”

“Six years ago, . . . the company had to pay extremely high federal taxes.”

◀ EXAMPLE

Exclamation Point (!)

Use an *exclamation point* after strong statements, commands, or interjections.

You must work harder!
Do not use the machine!
Danger!

◀ EXAMPLE

Hyphen (-)

A *hyphen* is used in the following ways.

1. To indicate the division of a word at the end of a typed line. Remember, this division must occur between syllables.
2. To create a compound adjective.

EXAMPLE ►

He is a well-known engineer.
Until her death in 2014, she was a world-renowned chemist.
Tom is a 24-hour-a-day student.

3. To join the numerator and denominator of fractions.

EXAMPLE ►

Four-fifths of the company want to initiate profit sharing.

4. To write out two-word numbers.

EXAMPLE ►

Twenty-six people attended the conference.

Parentheses ()

Parentheses enclose abbreviations, numbers, words, or sentences for the following reasons.

1. To define a term or provide an abbreviation for later use.

EXAMPLE ►

We belong to the Society for Technical Communication (STC).

2. To clarify preceding information in a sentence.

EXAMPLE ►

The people in attendance (all regional sales managers) were proud of their accomplishments.

3. To number items in a series.

EXAMPLE ►

The company should initiate (1) new personnel practices, (2) a probationary review board, and (3) biannual raises.

Period (.)

A *period* must end a declarative sentence (independent clause).

EXAMPLE ►

I found the business trip rewarding.

Periods are often used with abbreviations.

D.C.	Mrs.	A.M. or a.m.
e.g.	Ms.	P.M. or p.m.
Mr.		

It is incorrect to use periods with abbreviations for organizations and associations.

incorrect

S.T.C. (Society for Technical Communication)

correct

STC (Society for Technical Communication)

State abbreviations do not require periods if you use two capital letters. (Continue to use a period after a capital letter and a lowercase letter such as Tx., Ks., or Mo.)

incorrect

KS. (Kansas)
MO. (Missouri)
TX. (Texas)

correct

KS
MO
TX

Question Mark (?)

Use a *question mark* after direct questions.

Do the lab results support your theory?
Will you work at the main office or at the branch?

◀ **EXAMPLE**

Quotation Marks (" ")

Quotation marks are used in the following ways.

1. When citing direct quotations.

He said, "Your division sold the most compressors last year."

◀ **EXAMPLE**

NOTE: When you are citing a quotation within a quotation, use double quotation marks (" ") and single quotation marks (').

Kim's supervisor, quoting the CEO, said the following to explain the new policy regarding raises: "Only employees who deserve them will receive merit raises."

◀ **EXAMPLE**

2. To note the title of an article or a subdivision of a report.

EXAMPLE ►

The article “Robotics in Industry Today” was an excellent choice as the basis of your speech.
Section III, “Waste Water in District 9,” is pertinent to our discussion.

When using quotation marks, abide by the following punctuation conventions:

- Commas and periods always go *inside* quotation marks.

EXAMPLE ►

She said, “Our percentages are fixed.”

- Colons and semicolons always go *outside* quotation marks.

EXAMPLE ►

He said, “The supervisor hasn’t decided yet”; however, he added that the decision would be made soon.

- Exclamation points and question marks go inside the quotation marks if the quoted material is either exclamatory or a question. However, if the quoted material is not exclamatory or a question, then these punctuation marks go outside the quotation marks.

EXAMPLE ►

John said, “Don’t touch that liquid. It’s boiling!”

(Although the sentence isn’t exclamatory, the quotation is. Thus, the exclamation point goes inside the quotation marks.)

EXAMPLE ►

How could she say, “We haven’t purchased the equipment yet”?

(Although the quotation isn’t a question, the sentence is. Thus, the question mark goes outside the quotation marks.)

Semicolon (;)

Semicolons are used in the following instances.

1. Between two independent clauses *not* joined by a coordinating conjunction.

EXAMPLE ►

The light source was unusual; it emanated from a crack in the plastic surrounding the cathode.

2. To separate items in a series containing internal commas.

EXAMPLE ►

When the meeting was called to order, all members were present, including Susan Johnson, the president; Jewel Smith, the vice president; Harold Holbert, the treasurer; and Linda Hamilton, the secretary.

Mechanics

Abbreviations

Never use an abbreviation that your reader will not understand. A key to clear technical writing is to write on a level appropriate to your reader. You may use the following familiar abbreviations without explanation: *Mrs.*, *Dr.*, *Mr.*, *Ms.*, and *Jr.*

A common mistake is to abbreviate inappropriately. For example, some writers abbreviate *and* as follows:

I quit my job & planned to retire young.

◀ **EXAMPLE**

This is too colloquial for professional technical writing. Spell out *and* when you write.

The majority of abbreviation errors occur when writers incorrectly abbreviate states and technical terms.

States. Writers often abbreviate the names of states incorrectly. Use the U.S. Postal Service abbreviations in addresses.

Abbreviations for States

AL	Alabama	MT	Montana
AK	Alaska	NC	North Carolina
AZ	Arizona	ND	North Dakota
AR	Arkansas	NE	Nebraska
CA	California	NV	Nevada
CO	Colorado	NH	New Hampshire
CT	Connecticut	NJ	New Jersey
DE	Delaware	NM	New Mexico
FL	Florida	NY	New York
GA	Georgia	OH	Ohio
HI	Hawaii	OK	Oklahoma
IN	Indiana	OR	Oregon
IA	Iowa	PA	Pennsylvania
ID	Idaho	RI	Rhode Island
IL	Illinois	SC	South Carolina
KS	Kansas	SD	South Dakota
KY	Kentucky	TN	Tennessee
LA	Louisiana	TX	Texas
ME	Maine	UT	Utah
MD	Maryland	VT	Vermont
MA	Massachusetts	VA	Virginia
MI	Michigan	WA	Washington
MN	Minnesota	WV	West Virginia
MS	Mississippi	WI	Wisconsin
MO	Missouri	WY	Wyoming

Technical Terms. Units of measurement and scientific terms must be abbreviated accurately to ensure that they will be understood. Writers often use such abbreviations incorrectly. For example, “The unit measured 7.9 cent.” is inaccurate. The correct abbreviation for centimeter is *cm*, not *cent*. Use the following abbreviation conventions.

Technical Abbreviations for Units of Measurement and Scientific Terms

absolute	abs	current (electric)	I
alternating current	AC	cycles per second	CPS
American wire gauge	AWG	decibel	dB
ampere	amp	decigram	dg
ampere-hour	amp-hr	deciliter	dI
amplitude modulation	AM	decimeter	dm
angstrom unit	Å	degree	deg
atmosphere	atm	dekagram	dkg
atomic weight	at wt	dekaliter	dkl
audio frequency	AF	dekameter	dkm
azimuth	az	dewpoint	DP
barometer	bar.	diameter	dia
barrel, barrels	bbl	direct current	DC
billion electron volts	BeV	dozen	doz (or dz)
biochemical oxygen demand	BOD	dram	dr
board foot	bdf	electromagnetic force	emf
Brinell hardness number	BHN	electron volt	eV
British thermal unit	Btu	elevation	el (or elev)
bushel	bu	equivalent	equiv
calorie	cal	Fahrenheit	F
candela	cd	farad	F
Celsius	C	faraday	f
center of gravity	cg	feet, foot	ft
centimeter	cm	feet per second	ft/sec
circumference	cir	fluid ounce	floz
cologarithm	colog	foot board measure	fbm
continuous wave	CW	foot-candle	ft-c
cosine	cos	foot-pound	ftlb
cotangent	cot	frequency modulation	FM
cubic centimeter	cc	gallon	gal
cubic foot	cu ft (or ft ³)	gallons per day	GPD
cubic feet per second	cfs	gallons per minute	GPM
cubic inch	cu in. (or in. ³)	grain	gr
cubic meter	cu m (or m ³)	grams	g (or gm)
cubic yard	cu yd (or yd ³)	gravitational acceleration	g

(continued)

ROUTINE CORRESPONDENCE

hectare	ha	maximum	max
hectoliter	hl	megacycle	mc
hectometer	hm	megahertz	MHz
henry	H	megawatt	MW
hertz	Hz	meter	m
high frequency	HF	microampere	μamp
horsepower	hp	microinch	μin.
horsepower-hours	hp-hr	microsecond	μsec
hour	hr	microwatt	μw
hundredweight	cwt	miles per gallon	mpg
inch	in.	milliampere	mA
inch-pounds	in.-lb	millibar	mb
infrared	IR	millifarad	mF
inner diameter or inside dimensions	ID	milligram	mg
intermediate frequency	IF	milliliter	ml
international unit	IU	millimeter	mm
joule	J	millivolt	mV
Kelvin	K	milliwatt	mW
kilocalorie	kcal	minute	min
kilocycle	kc	nautical mile	NM
kilocycles per second	kc/sec	negative	neg or -
kilogram	kg	number	no.
kilohertz	kHz	octane	oct
kilojoule	kJ	ounce	oz
kiloliter	kl	outside diameter	OD
kilometer	km	parts per billion	ppb
kilovolt	kV	parts per million	ppm
kilovolt-amperes	kVa	pascal	pas
kilowatt-hours	kWH	positive	pos or +
lambert	L	pound	lb
latitude	lat	pounds per square inch	psi
length	l	pounds per square inch absolute	psia
linear	lin	pounds per square inch gauge	psig
linear foot	linft	quart	qt
liter	l	radio frequency	RF
logarithm	log.	radian	rad
longitude	long.	radius	r
low frequency	LF	resistance	r
lumen	lm	revolution	rev
lumen-hour	lm-hr	revolutions per minute	rpm
		second	s (or sec)

Technical Abbreviations for Units of Measurement and Scientific Terms (continued)

secant	sec	ultra high frequency	UHF
specific gravity	sp gr (or SG)	vacuum	vac
square foot	ft ²	very high frequency	VHF
square inch	in. ²	volt-ampere	VA
square meter	m ²	volt	V
square mile	mi ²	volts per meter	V/m
tablespoon	tbs (or tbsp)	volume	vol
tangent	tan	watt-hour	whr
teaspoon	tsp	watt	W
temperature	t	wavelength	WL
tensile strength	ts	weight	wt
thousand	m	yards	y (or yd)
ton	t	years	y (or yr)

Capital Letters

Capitalize the following:

1. Proper nouns.

EXAMPLE ►

people	cities	countries	companies	schools	buildings
Susan	Houston	Italy	Bendix	Harvard	Oak Park Mall

2. People's titles (only when they precede the name).

EXAMPLE ►

Governor Sally Renfro
or
Sally Renfro, governor
Technical Supervisor Todd Blackman
or
Wes Schneider, the technical supervisor

3. Titles of books, magazines, plays, movies, television programs, and CDs (excluding the prepositions and all articles after the first article in the title).

EXAMPLE ►

Mad Men
The Colbert Report
The Catcher in the Rye
The Twilight Saga: Breaking Dawn
American Idol

4. Names of organizations.

Girl Scouts
Phoenix, AZ, Regional Home Care Association
Kansas City Regional Council for Higher Education
Programs for Technical and Scientific Communication
American Civil Liberties Union
Students for a Democratic Society

◀ EXAMPLE

5. Days of the week, months, and holidays.

Monday
December
Thanksgiving

◀ EXAMPLE

6. Races, religions, and nationalities.

American Indian
Jewish
Polish

◀ EXAMPLE

7. Events or eras in history.

the Gulf War
the Vietnam War
World War II

◀ EXAMPLE

8. North, South, East, and West (when used to indicate geographic locations).

Atlanta is one of the fastest growing cities in the South.

◀ EXAMPLE

NOTE: Don't capitalize these words when giving directions.

We were told to drive south three blocks and then to turn west.

◀ EXAMPLE

9. The first word of a sentence.

10. Don't capitalize any of the following:

Seasons—spring, fall, summer, winter
Names of classes—sophomore, senior
General groups—middle management, infielders, surgeons

◀ EXAMPLE

Numbers

Write out numbers one through nine. Use numerals for numbers 10 and above.

10	12
104	2,093
536	5,550,286

Although the preceding rules cover most situations, there are exceptions.

1. Use numerals for all percentages.

EXAMPLE ►

2 percent	18 percent	25 percent
-----------	------------	------------

2. Use numerals for addresses.

EXAMPLE ►

12 Elm	935 W. Harding
--------	----------------

3. Use numerals for miles per hour.

EXAMPLE ►

5 mph	225 mph
-------	---------

4. Use numerals for time.

EXAMPLE ►

3:15 A.M.

5. Use numerals for dates.

EXAMPLE ►

May 31, 2014

6. Use numerals for monetary values.

EXAMPLE ►

\$45	\$.95	\$2 million
------	-------	-------------

7. Use numerals for units of measurement.

EXAMPLE ►

14 feet	6 3/4 inches	16 mm 10 V
---------	--------------	------------

8. Do not use numerals to begin sentences.

incorrect

568 people were fired last August.

correct

Five hundred sixty-eight people were fired last August.

9. Do not mix numerals and words when writing numbers. When two or more numbers appear in a sentence and one of them is 10 or more, figures are used.

We attended 4 meetings over a 16-day period.

◀ EXAMPLE

10. Use numerals and words in a compound number adjective to avoid confusion.

The worker needed six 2-inch nails.

◀ EXAMPLE

Spelling

The following is a list of commonly misspelled or misused words. You can avoid many common spelling errors if you familiarize yourself with these words. Remember to run spell check; also remember that spell check will not understand context. The incorrect word contextually could be spelled correctly.

accept, except	council, counsel	personal, personnel
addition, edition	desert, dessert	principal, principle
access, excess	disburse, disperse	quiet, quite
advise, advice	fiscal, physical	rite, right, write
affect, effect	forth, fourth	stationery, stationary
all ready, already	incite, insight	their, there, they're
assistants, assistance	its, it's	to, too, two
bare, bear	loose, lose	whose, who's
brake, break	miner, minor	your, you're
coarse, course	passed, past	
cite, site, sight	patients, patience	

Apply Your Knowledge

Spelling

In the following sentences, circle the correctly spelled words within the parentheses.

- Each of the employees attended the meeting (accept except) the line supervisor, who was out of town for job-related travel.
- The (advise advice) he gave will help us all do a better job.
- Management must (affect effect) a change in employees' attitudes toward absenteeism.
- Let me (site cite sight) this most recent case as an example.
- (Its It's) too early to tell if our personnel changes will help create a better office environment.
- If we (lose loose) another good employee to our competitor, our production capabilities will suffer.
- I'm not (quite quiet) sure what she meant by that comment.
- (Their There They're) budget has gotten too large to ensure a successful profit margin.
- We had wanted to attend the conference (to too two), but our tight schedule prevented us from doing so.
- (You're Your) best chance for landing this contract is to manufacture a better product.

In the following letter, correct the misspelled words.

March 5, 2014

Joanna Freeman
Personel Director
United Teletype
1111 E. Street
Kansas City, MO 68114

Dear Ms. Freeman:

Your advertizmemt in the Febuary 18, 2014, Kansas City Star is just the opening I have been looking for. I would like to submit my quallifications.

As you will note in the inclosed resum, I recieved an Enginneering degree from the Missouri Institute of Technology in 2005 and have worked in the electronic enginneering department of General Accounts for three years. I have worked a great deal in design electronics for microprocesors, controll systems, ect.

Because your company has invented many extrordinary design projects, working at your company would give me more chances to use my knowlege aquired in school and through my expirences. If you are interested in my quallifications, I would be happy to discuss them futher with you. I look foreward to hearing from you.

Sincerely,

Bob Cottrell
Bob Cottrell

Fragments and Comma Splices

In the following sentences, correct the fragments and comma splices by inserting the appropriate punctuation or adding any necessary words.

1. She kept her appointment with the salesperson, however, the rest of her staff came late.
2. When the CEO presented his fiscal year projections, he tried to motivate his employees, many were not excited about the proposed cuts.
3. Even though the company's sales were up 25 percent.
4. The supervisor wanted the staff members to make suggestions for improving their work environment, the employees, however, felt that any grievances should be taken directly to their union representatives.
5. Which he decided was an excellent idea.
6. Because their machinery was prone to malfunctions and often caused hazards to the workers.
7. They needed the equipment to complete their job responsibilities, further delays would cause production slowdowns.
8. Their client who was a major distributor of high-tech machinery.
9. Robotics should help us maintain schedules, we'll need to avoid equipment malfunctions, though.
10. The company, careful not to make false promises, advertising their product in media releases.

In the following letter, correct the fragments and comma splices.

May 12, 2014

Maurene Pierce
Dean of Residence Life
Mann College
Mannsville, NY 10012

Subject: Report on Dormitory Damage Systems

Here is the report you authorized on April 5 for an analysis of the current dormitory damage system used in this college.

The purpose of the report was to determine the effectiveness of the system. And to offer any concrete recommendations for improvement. To do this, I analyzed in detail the damage cost figures for the past three years, I also did an extensive study of dormitory conditions. Although I had limited manpower. I gathered information on all seven dormitories, focusing specifically on the men's athletic dorm, located at 1201 Chester. In this dorm, bathroom facilities, carpeting, and air conditioning are most susceptible to damage. Along with closet doors.

Nonetheless, my immediate findings indicate that the system is functioning well, however, improvements in the physical characteristics of the dormitories, such as new carpeting and paint, would make the system even more efficient.

I have enjoyed conducting this study, I hope my findings help you make your final decision. Please contact me. If I can be of further assistance.



Rob Harken

Punctuation

In the following sentences, circle the correct punctuation marks. If no punctuation is needed, draw a slash mark through both options.

1. John took an hour for lunch (, ;) but Joan stayed at her desk to eat so she could complete the project.
2. Sally wrote the specifications (, ;) Randy was responsible for adding any needed graphics.
3. Manufacturing maintained a 93.5 percent production rating in July (, ;) therefore, the department earned the Golden Circle Award at the quarterly meeting.
4. In their year-end requests to management (, ;) supervisors asked for new office equipment (, ;) and a 10 percent budget increase for staffing.
5. The following employees attended the training session on stress management (, :) Steve Janasz, purchasing agent (, ;) Jeremy Kreisler, personnel director (, ;) and Prakash Patel, staff supervisor.
6. Promotions were given to all sales personnel (, ;) secretaries, however, received only cost-of-living raises.
7. The technicians voted for better work benefits (, ;) as an incentive to improve morale.
8. Although the salespeople were happy with their salary increases (, ;) the technicians felt slighted.
9. First (, ;) let's remember that meeting schedules should be a priority (, ;) and not an afterthought.
10. The employee (, ;) who achieves the highest rating this month (, ;) will earn 10 bonus points (, ;) therefore (, ;) competition should be intense.

ROUTINE CORRESPONDENCE

In the letter below, no punctuation has been added. Instead, there are blanks where punctuation might be inserted. First, decide whether any punctuation is needed (not every blank requires punctuation). Then, insert the correct punctuation—a comma, colon, period, semicolon, or question mark.

January 8_ 2014

Mr_ Ron Schaefer
1324 Homes
Carbondale_ IL_ 34198

Dear Mr_ Schaefer_

Yesterday_ my partners_ and I read about your invention in the Herald Tribune_ and we want to congratulate you on this new idea_ and ask you to work with us on a similar project_

We cannot wait to begin our project_ however_ before we can do so_ I would like you to answer the following questions_

- Has your invention been tested in salt water_
- What is the cost of replacement parts_
- What is your fee for consulting_

Once_ I receive your answers to these questions_ my partners and I will contact you regarding a schedule for operations_ We appreciate your design concept_ and know it will help our business tremendously_ We look forward to hearing from you_

Sincerely_



Elias Agamenyon

Agreement (Subject/Verb and Pronoun/Antecedent)

In the following sentences, circle the correct choice to achieve agreement between subject and verb or pronoun and antecedent.

1. The employees, though encouraged by the possibility of increased overtime, (was were) still dissatisfied with their current salaries.
2. The supervisor wants to manufacture better products, but (they he) doesn't know how to motivate the technicians to improve their work habits.
3. The staff (was were) happy when the new manager canceled the proposed meeting.
4. Anyone who wants (his or her their) vote recorded must attend the annual board meeting.
5. According to the printed work schedule, Susan and Tom (work works) today on the manufacturing line.
6. According to the printed work schedule, either Susan or Tom (work works) today on the manufacturing line.
7. Although Tamara is responsible for distributing all monthly activity reports, (she they) failed to mail them.
8. Every one of the engineers asked if (he or she they) could be assigned to the project.
9. Either the supervisor or the technicians (is are) at fault.
10. The CEO, known for her generosity to employees and their families, (has have) been nominated for the humanitarian award.

In the following memo, find and correct the errors in agreement.

MEMO

DATE: October 30, 2014
TO: Tammy West
FROM: Susan Lisk
SUBJECT: REPORT ON AIR HANDLING UNIT

There has been several incidents involving the unit which has resulted in water damage to the computer systems located below the air handler.

The occurrences yesterday was caused when a valve was closed creating condensation to be forced through a humidifier element into the supply air duct. Water then leaked from the duct into the room below causing substantial damage to four disc-drive units.

To prevent recurrence of this type of damage, the following actions has been initiated by maintenance supervision:

- Each supervisor must ensure that their subordinates remove condensation valves to avoid unauthorized operation.
- Everyone must be made aware that they are responsible for closing condensation valves.
- The supply air duct, modified to carry away harmful sediments, are to be drained monthly.

Maintenance supervision recommend that air handlers not be installed above critical equipment. This will avoid the possibility of coil failure and water damage.

Capitalization

In the following memo, nothing has been capitalized. Capitalize those words requiring capitalization.

date: december 5, 2014
to: jordan cottrell
from: richard davis
subject: self-contained breathing apparatus (scba) and negative pressure respirator evaluation and fit-testing report

the evaluation and fit-testing have been accomplished. the attached list identifies the following:

- supervisors and electronic technicians who have used the scba successfully.
- the negative pressure respirators used for testing in an isoamyl acetate atmosphere.

fit-testing of waste management personnel will be accomplished annually, according to president chuck carlson. new supervisors and technicians will be fit-tested when hired.

all apex corporation personnel located in the new york district (12304 parkview lane) must submit a request form when requesting a respirator or scba for use. any waste management personnel in the north and south facilities not identified on the attached list will be fit-tested when use of scba is required. if you have any questions, contact chuck carlson or me (richard davis, district manager) at ext. 4036.

Grammar Quiz

The following sentences contain errors in spelling, punctuation, verb and pronoun agreement, sentence structure (fragments and fused sentences), and modification. Circle the letter corresponding to the section of the sentence containing the error.

◀ EXAMPLE

When you recieve the salary increase, your family will celebrate the occassion.

A

B

C

- Each department manager should his tell subordinates to advise of any negative occurrences regarding in-house training.
A B C D
- The lawyers' new offices were similar to their former ones _____ the offices were on a quiet street.
A B C D
- New York City is divided into five boroughs ; Manhattan, the Bronx, Queens, Brooklyn, and Staten Island.
A B C D
- Fashion consultants explain that clothes create a strong impression _____ so they advise executives _____ to choose wardrobes carefully.
A B C D
- Everyone should make sure that they are well represented in union meetings ; otherwise , management could become too powerful.
A B C D
- The employment agency , too busy to return the telephone calls from prospective clients , are harming business opportunities.
A B C D
- The supervisory staff are making decisions based on scheduling , but all employees want to ensure quality control.
A B C D
- Because the price of cars has risen dramatically _____ most people keep their cars longer _____ to save capital expenditures.
A B C D
- The department's manager heard that a merger was possible _____ but he decided to keep the news quiet.
A B C D
- The manager of the department believed that her employee's were excellent , but she decided that no raises could be given _____ because the price of stocks was falling.
A B C D

ROUTINE CORRESPONDENCE

11. The detailed report from the audit _____ of the department gave good advise

A
B

about how to restructure , so we are all ready to do so.

C
D
12. When my boss and I looked at the books , we found these problems ; lost invoices,

A
B
C

unpaid bills , and late payments.

D
13. The most dedicated staff members are accepted for the on-site training sessions

A
B

because ; they are responsive to criticism, represent the company's future, and strive

C
D

for improvements.
14. Despite her assurances to the contrary , there is still three unanswered questions ; who

A
B
C

will make the payments, when will these payments occur, and why is there a delay?

D
15. The reputation of many companies often depend on one employee who represents

A
B
C
D

that company.
16. Either my monthly activity report or my year - end report are due today , but my

A
B
C

computer is broken ; therefore, I need to use yours.

D
17. Today's American manpower , according to many foreign governments, suffers

A
B
C
D

from lack of discipline.
18. Rates are increasing next year because ; fuel, maintenance, and insurance are

A
B
C

all higher than last year.

D
19. Many colleges have long-standing football rivalries , one of the most famous ones

A
B

is between KU and KSU (two universities in Kansas).

C
D
20. Everyone who wants to enroll in the business school should do so before June

A
B

if they can to ensure getting the best classes.

C
D
21. Because John wanted high visibility for his two business , he paid top dollar

A
B

_____ and spent long hours looking for appropriate cites.

C
D
22. Many people apply for jobs at Apex , however , only a few are accepted.

A
B
C
D

ROUTINE CORRESPONDENCE

23. Because most cars break down occasionally, all drivers should know how to change
A B
a flat tire, and how to signal for assistance.
C D
24. Arriving on time, working diligently, and closing the office securely == everyone
A B
needs to know that they are responsible for these job duties.
C D
25. Mark McGwire not only hit the ball further than other players, but also he hit
A B
more dingers than other players who hit fewer homers.
C D

LETTER FORMATS

Three common types of letter formats include **full block** (Figure 1), **full block with subject line** (Figure 2), and **simplified** (Figure 3). Two popular and professional formats used in business are full block and full block with subject line. With both formats, you type all information at the left margin without indenting paragraphs, the date, the complimentary close, or signature. The full block with subject line differs only with the inclusion of a subject line.

Another option is the simplified format. This type of letter layout is similar to the full block format in that all text is typed margin left. The two significant omissions include no salutation (“Dear ____:”) and no complimentary close (“Sincerely,”). Omitting a salutation is useful in the following instances:

- You do not know your reader’s name (NOTE: Avoid the trite salutation, “To Whom It May Concern:”).
- You are writing to someone with a non-gender specific name (Jesse, Terry, Stacy, Chris, etc.) and you do not know whether to use “Mr.,” “Mrs.,” or “Ms.”

The Administrative Management Society (AMS) suggests that if you omit the salutation, you also should omit the complimentary close. Some people feel that omitting the salutation and the complimentary close will make the letter cold and unfriendly. However, the AMS says that if your letter is warm and friendly, these omissions will not be missed. More importantly, if your letter’s content is negative, beginning with “Dear” and ending with “Sincerely” will not improve the letter’s tone or your reader’s attitude toward your comments. The simplified format includes a subject line to aid the letter’s clarity.

FIGURE 1 Full Block Format

State Health Department 1890 Clark Road Jefferson City, MO 67220 June 6, 2014 Dale McGraw, Manager Elmwood Mobile Home Park Elmwood, MO 64003 Dear Mr. McGraw: On April 19, 2014, Ryan Duran and I, environmental specialists from the Health Department, conducted an inspection of the Elmwood Mobile Home Park Wastewater Treatment Facility. The purpose was to assess compliance with the following: the state's Clean Water Law, Clean Water Commission regulations, and your facility's plan for pollution control. The inspection also would allow the state to promote proper operation of Wastewater Facilities and to provide technical assistance where needed to the Elmwood Mobile Homes management. Though the Elmwood Mobile Home pollution control plan had expired in 2013, a consent judgment was issued by the state's Attorney General's Office. The county court stipulated a timeline for correction by connection to an available sewer system. Your mobile home park's wastewater system has continually discharged to the Little Osage River. A copy of the abatement order, which requires that monthly discharge monitoring reports (DMRs) be submitted by the 28th of the month following the reporting periods, is attached. All DMRs for the previous twelve months have been received, and reported pollution parameters are not within limits. Due to the plant's performance, the stream was placed on the 2012 303 (d) stream for impairment by the Elmwood Mobile Home. As part of the inspection, a review of the facility's DMR was conducted. Twenty-four-hour composite samples were collected using a composite sampler. Attached are the results of the 24-hour composite samples collected on April 20, 2014. Every one of the problems documented is an infraction that must be addressed. <u>Within 30 days</u> of receipt of this letter, please submit to the Health Department written documentation describing steps taken to correct each of the concerns identified in the attachments. Also include engineering reports, and submit a timeframe to eliminate the problems. Thank you for your cooperation. Sincerely, <i>Harvey Haddix</i> Harvey Haddix Environmental Manager Attachment	1 to 1½ in margins on all sides of the letter Two to four spaces above and below the date Two to four spaces above and below the salutation Single space within the paragraphs. Double space between the paragraphs. Two spaces before "Sincerely" Four spaces between "Sincerely" and the typed signature
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FIGURE 2 Full Block Format with Subject Line**State Health Department**

1890 Clark Road
Jefferson City, MO 67220

June 6, 2014

Dale McGraw, Manager
Elmwood Mobile Home Park
Elmwood, MO 64003

Subject: Pollution Control Inspection

Dear Mr. McGraw:

On April 19, 2014, Ryan Duran and I, environmental specialists from the Health Department, conducted an inspection of the Elmwood Mobile Home Park Wastewater Treatment Facility. The purpose was to assess compliance with the following: the state's Clean Water Law, Clean Water Commission regulations, and your facility's plan for pollution control. The inspection also would allow the state to promote proper operation of Wastewater Facilities and to provide technical assistance where needed to the Elmwood Mobile Homes management.

Though the Elmwood Mobile Home pollution control plan had expired in 2013, a consent judgment was issued by the state's Attorney General's Office. The county court stipulated a timeline for correction by connection to an available sewer system. Your mobile home park's wastewater system has continually discharged to the Little Osage River. A copy of the abatement order, which requires that monthly discharge monitoring reports (DMRs) be submitted by the 28th of the month following the reporting periods, is attached. All DMRs for the previous twelve months have been received, and reported pollution parameters are not within limits. Due to the plant's performance, the stream was placed on the 2012 303 (d) stream for impairment by the Elmwood Mobile Home.

As part of the inspection, a review of the facility's DMR was conducted. Twenty-four-hour composite samples were collected using a composite sampler. Attached are the results of the 24-hour composite samples collected on April 20, 2014. Every one of the problems documented is an infraction that must be addressed.

Within 30 days of receipt of this letter, please submit to the Health Department written documentation describing steps taken to correct each of the concerns identified in the attachments. Also include engineering reports, and submit a timeframe to eliminate the problems. Thank you for your cooperation.

Sincerely,

Harvey Haddix

Harvey Haddix
Environmental Manager

Attachment

FIGURE 3 Simplified Format Omitting “Dear . . .” and “Sincerely”

State Health Department

1890 Clark Road
Jefferson City, MO 67220

June 6, 2014

Dale McGraw, Manager
Elmwood Mobile Home Park
Elmwood, MO 64003

Subject: Pollution Control Inspection

On April 19, 2014, Ryan Duran and I, environmental specialists from the Health Department, conducted an inspection of the Elmwood Mobile Home Park Wastewater Treatment Facility. The purpose was to assess compliance with the following: the state’s Clean Water Law, Clean Water Commission regulations, and your facility’s plan for pollution control. The inspection also would allow the state to promote proper operation of Wastewater Facilities and to provide technical assistance where needed to the Elmwood Mobile Homes management.

Though the Elmwood Mobile Home pollution control plan had expired in 2013, a consent judgment was issued by the state’s Attorney General’s Office. The county court stipulated a timeline for correction by connection to an available sewer system. Your mobile home park’s wastewater system has continually discharged to the Little Osage River. A copy of the abatement order, which requires that monthly discharge monitoring reports (DMRs) be submitted by the 28th of the month following the reporting periods, is attached. All DMRs for the previous twelve months have been received, and reported pollution parameters are not within limits. Due to the plant’s performance, the stream was placed on the 2012 303 (d) stream for impairment by the Elmwood Mobile Home.

As part of the inspection, a review of the facility’s DMR was conducted. Twenty-four-hour composite samples were collected using a composite sampler. Attached are the results of the 24-hour composite samples collected on April 20, 2014. Every one of the problems documented is an infraction that must be addressed.

Within 30 days of receipt of this letter, please submit to the Health Department written documentation describing steps taken to correct each of the concerns identified in the attachments. Also include engineering reports, and submit a timeframe to eliminate the problems. Thank you for your cooperation.

Harvey Haddix

Harvey Haddix
Environmental Manager

Attachment

PHOTO CREDITS

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